

Finance Career Playbook

Practical, Hands-On, Job-Ready — India-first + Global

Real formulas, queries, entries & tools — closing the gap between what an MBA teaches and what finance employers pay for

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The education-vs-industry gap, quantified

What it is & where it's used

An MBA (or B.Com, or CA Intermediate) certifies that you *understand* finance. A payroll certifies that you can *produce* finance work — a reconciled ledger, a filed GST return, a working three-statement model, a clean variance report — by a deadline, unsupervised, in the tools the company already runs.

Those are different products. The gap between them is what this whole book is about. It shows up in every finance/accounts/tax seat you might target:

Role	What college trained	What the job actually measures
Accounts Payable / AR executive	Journal-entry theory, accounting standards	Speed of 3-way match, Tally/ERP entry accuracy, vendor recon
GST / Tax associate	Sections of the CGST Act	Filing GSTR-1/3B on the portal, ITC reconciliation (2B vs books)
FP&A / Finance analyst	NPV, IRR formulas	Excel modelling, variance decks, pulling actuals from an ERP
Data-heavy finance / MIS	Ratio analysis	SQL to extract, Power BI/DAX to present, Python to automate
Audit associate	Auditing standards	Sampling in Excel, tick-and-tie, documenting workpapers

Every one of these is a *doing* skill layered on top of the theory you already have. Employers do not pay for the theory. They pay for the output.

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

College is optimised for a written exam graded on *conceptual correctness*. Industry is optimised for *repeatable, auditable output under a deadline*. Five concrete gaps result:

1. **Tools.** No MBA syllabus makes you fast in Excel, Tally, SAP, the GST portal, SQL, or Power BI. Firms assume you already are. You are not.
2. **Speed & unaided delivery.** Exams give you 3 hours and a clean question. Jobs give you a messy export, a 5 pm deadline, and no answer key. The bar is "get it right the first time without asking."
3. **Data plumbing.** Real numbers live in ERPs and CSV dumps, not in a textbook table. Nobody taught you `VLOOKUP` / `XLOOKUP` , pivot tables, or a `JOIN` . A ₹40-crore reconciliation is a lookup problem, not a theory problem.
4. **Documentation & audit trail.** "Show your working" in an exam is worth marks; in a job it is a legal and audit requirement. You must leave a trail a reviewer can follow.
5. **Communication.** A 40-mark essay is never asked for. A one-slide "here's why margin dropped 180 bps" is asked for constantly.

The punchline: "**what you can do**" **beats the degree** because the degree is a *filter* (it gets your CV read) while demonstrable skill is the *decision*. Two candidates with the same MBA are separated entirely by who

can open Excel and build the model live.

What "proficient" looks like

The concrete, unaided bar an employer tests for:

- Open a raw ERP/bank CSV and reconcile it to the books in **under 30 minutes** with `XLOOKUP` + a pivot, flagging every mismatch.
- Build a **3-statement model** where the balance sheet balances and a single driver (sales growth) flows through all three statements without hardcoding.
- File **GSTR-3B** on the portal and reconcile **ITC in books vs GSTR-2B**, explaining every difference.
- Write a **SQL query** with a `JOIN` and `GROUP BY` to answer "revenue by region by month" from a transactions table.
- Pass **journal entries** for accruals, prepaid, depreciation and a GST invoice — with correct Dr/Cr — cold.
- Turn a 50,000-row export into a **Power BI / pivot dashboard** with a YoY-growth measure.

If you can do these unaided, you are ahead of most fresh MBAs and many experienced hires.

Hands-on: how to actually do it

Excel — the reconciliation lookup (replace VLOOKUP forever):

```
=XLOOKUP(A2, Bank[Ref], Bank[Amount], "NOT IN BANK", 0)
```

Then flag mismatches vs the books:

```
=IF(ROUND(BookAmt - XLOOKUP(A2, Bank[Ref], Bank[Amount], 0), 2)=0, "OK", "CHECK")
```

Aggregate for a quick summary without a pivot:

```
=SUMIFS(Ledger[Amount], Ledger[Region], "South", Ledger[Month], "Apr")
```

SQL — revenue by region by month from a transactions table:

```
SELECT region,
       DATE_FORMAT(txn_date, '%Y-%m') AS month,
       SUM(amount) AS revenue
FROM   sales_txns
WHERE  txn_date ≥ '2025-04-01'
GROUP BY region, DATE_FORMAT(txn_date, '%Y-%m')
ORDER BY region, month;
```

ITC-style reconciliation as a `LEFT JOIN` (books vs portal):

```
SELECT b.invoice_no, b.itc AS books_itc, g.itc AS portal_itc,
       (b.itc - COALESCE(g.itc,0)) AS diff
FROM   books_itc b
LEFT   JOIN gstr2b g ON b.invoice_no = g.invoice_no
WHERE  b.itc > COALESCE(g.itc,0);
```

Python — automate a monthly reconciliation (pandas):

```
import pandas as pd

books = pd.read_excel("books.xlsx")
bank  = pd.read_csv("bank_statement.csv")

merged = books.merge(bank, on="ref", how="outer",
                     suffixes=("_book", "_bank"), indicator=True)
merged["diff"] = merged["amount_book"].fillna(0) - merged["amount_bank"].fillna(0)

unmatched = merged[(merged["_merge"] != "both") | (merged["diff"].abs() > 0.01)]
unmatched.to_excel("exceptions.xlsx", index=False)
print(f"{len(unmatched)} exceptions of {len(merged)} rows")
```

DAX — a YoY growth measure in Power BI:

```
Revenue YoY % =
VAR ThisYr = [Total Revenue]
VAR LastYr = CALCULATE([Total Revenue], DATEADD('Date'[Date], -1, YEAR))
RETURN DIVIDE(ThisYr - LastYr, LastYr)
```

TallyPrime — record a purchase with GST (click-path): Gateway of Tally → Vouchers → F9 (Purchase) → select Party → select Purchase ledger → pick Stock item → Tally auto-computes CGST/SGST from the GST ledgers → Ctrl+A to save.

GST portal — file GSTR-3B: www.gst.gov.in → Login → Services → Returns → Returns Dashboard → select period → GSTR-3B "Prepare Online" → fill 3.1 outward tax & 4 eligible ITC → Save → Proceed to Payment → offset liability → File with EVC/DSC.

Journal entries — the ones you'll pass cold:

Transaction	Dr	Cr	Amount (₹)
Purchase of goods with GST (18%)	Purchases 1,00,000 / Input CGST 9,000 / Input SGST 9,000	To Creditor	1,18,000
Salary accrued, unpaid	Salary Expense	To Salary Payable	2,50,000
Prepaid insurance (paid)	Prepaid Insurance	To Bank	60,000
Monthly depreciation	Depreciation	To Accumulated Depreciation	12,500

Worked example / mini-project

Reproduce this in one sitting. You run accounts for a small trading firm. April sales ledger has 6 invoices; the bank shows 5 receipts.

Invoice	Book amount (₹)	Bank receipt (₹)
INV-001	1,18,000	1,18,000
INV-002	2,36,000	2,36,000
INV-003	59,000	59,000
INV-004	94,400	—
INV-005	1,77,000	1,77,000
INV-006	47,200	47,200

Step 1 — put invoices in column A, book amounts in B, bank data in a **Bank** table. In C2:

```
=XLOOKUP(A2, Bank[Inv], Bank[Amt], "NOT RECEIVED", 0)
```

Step 2 — status in D2:

```
=IF(C2="NOT RECEIVED", "OUTSTANDING", IF(ROUND(B2-C2, 2)=0, "OK", "DIFF"))
```

Step 3 — totals: `=SUM(B2:B7)` gives billed **₹7,31,600**; `=SUMIF(D2:D7, "OK", B2:B7)` gives collected **₹6,37,200**. Outstanding = **₹94,400** (INV-004).

Step 4 — the finance answer: collection efficiency = $\frac{6,37,200}{7,31,600} = 87.1\%$, one debtor (INV-004) is unpaid. You just did in five minutes what a "reconciliation" job title exists to do all month. Extend it: 500 invoices, same two formulas, and INV-004's GST of ₹14,400 is stuck ITC you'd chase in GSTR-2B.

How it's tested

Companies almost never test theory alone. Expect:

- **Timed Excel test (30-45 min):** given a raw CSV, "reconcile these two sheets and give me collection % and the exceptions list." Lookups, `SUMIFS`, a pivot, and IF-logic. Speed is scored.

- **SQL screen:** "write a query for top-5 customers by revenue this quarter." (`GROUP BY ... ORDER BY ... LIMIT 5` .)
- **Case / "close the books":** a trial balance with 8 adjustments — pass the entries, produce P&L and balance sheet.
- **Modelling round (FP&A):** build or extend a 3-statement or DCF model live; they watch your cell logic.
- **Interview questions:** "Walk me through the three statements and how they link." / "What's the entry for accrued expense?" / "How would you reconcile ITC?" / "Depreciation rises ₹100 — what happens to cash?" (Answer: net income down by $100 \times (1 - \text{tax})$, cash *up* by the tax shield since depreciation is non-cash.)

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

- **VLOOKUP with approximate match** silently returns wrong numbers. Pros use `XLOOKUP` , or `VLOOKUP( ... , FALSE)` at minimum.
- **Hardcoding numbers into model formulas.** A pro drives everything from a labelled assumptions block so one input change flows everywhere.
- **A balance sheet that doesn't balance** and "plugging" it. Pros build a `Assets - (Liab+Equity)` check cell that must read zero.
- **Reconciling on amount alone.** Two invoices of ₹59,000 net to zero difference but are the wrong match. Pros key on a unique ID (invoice/ref no.).
- **No audit trail.** Pros leave source, formula, and date so a reviewer reproduces the number without asking.
- **Filing GSTR-3B before reconciling 2B.** Over-claimed ITC gets reversed with interest. Pros reconcile books-vs-2B first.
- **Float comparison** (`=` on decimals). Wrap in `ROUND( ... , 2)` — always.

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Realistic time-to-proficiency, part-time, from an MBA/CA-Inter base:

Skill	To job-ready	Resource
Excel (lookups, pivots, IF)	3-4 weeks	ExcelJet, Chandoo.org (free); Microsoft Excel docs
Financial modelling	6-8 weeks	CFI FMVA (paid), Breaking Into Wall Street; Aswath Damodaran (free, YouTube)
SQL	3-4 weeks	SQLBolt, Mode SQL Tutorial (free); LeetCode DB
Power BI + DAX	4-6 weeks	Microsoft Learn (free); SQLBI.com for DAX
Python (pandas)	4-6 weeks	Kaggle "Pandas" micro-course (free)
Tally + GST	3-4 weeks	Tally Education (TallyPrime), CBIC GST portal help

Certifications that actually move a CV: **Microsoft Office Specialist – Excel, CFI FMVA, Tally Certification (TallyPrime), Microsoft PL-300 (Power BI)**. Sequence for an India accounts/tax role: Excel → Tally+GST →

SQL/Power BI. For FP&A/analyst: Excel → modelling → SQL. Build a public portfolio (one reconciliation, one model, one dashboard) — it beats any certificate in the interview.

Quick-reference

Need	Use
Look up a value	<code>=XLOOKUP(key, lookup_col, return_col, "NA", 0)</code>
Conditional sum	<code>=SUMIFS(sum, crit_rng1, c1, crit_rng2, c2)</code>
Match check	<code>=IF(ROUND(a-b,2)=0,"OK","CHECK")</code>
SQL group	<code>SELECT dim, SUM(x) FROM t GROUP BY dim ORDER BY 2 DESC</code>
SQL reconcile	<code>LEFT JOIN ... WHERE a.v <> COALESCE(b.v,0)</code>
Pandas reconcile	<code>df1.merge(df2, on="key", how="outer", indicator=True)</code>
YoY in DAX	<code>DIVIDE([X]-CALCULATE([X],DATEADD(Date,-1,YEAR)), ...)</code>
GST purchase entry	Dr Purchases + Dr Input CGST/SGST → Cr Creditor
Accrual entry	Dr Expense → Cr Payable
GST rate (standard)	18% = 9% CGST + 9% SGST (intra-state)
Balance check	<code>Assets - (Liabilities + Equity) = 0</code>
Golden rule	Debit what comes in / expenses; Credit what goes out / income

The Finance Role Map

What it is & where it's used

"Finance" on a job portal is a dozen different jobs wearing one label. A tax analyst and an M&A banker share almost no daily tools. Before you can build skills (the rest of this book), you need a map: who does what, what it pays, and how you get in. This chapter is that map.

The core split is **buy-side vs sell-side vs corporate vs assurance**:

- **Corporate finance** (inside a company): Accounting, Tax, FP&A, Treasury, Product Control. You keep the company's own books, forecasts, and cash.
- **Sell-side** (advises/intermediates): Investment Banking (IB), Equity Research (ER). You sell deals, advice, and coverage.
- **Buy-side** (invests capital): PE/VC, asset management, hedge funds. You deploy money to earn returns.
- **Assurance & control**: External Audit, Internal Audit, Credit, Risk. You verify, lend against, and constrain.

Every role below hires in India (Mumbai, Bengaluru, Gurugram, Hyderabad GCCs) and globally. Your MBA + CA-Inter combination is a strong fit for Accounting, Tax, FP&A, Credit, Audit, and Product Control immediately, and a stepping stone into IB/ER.

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

College teaches you to *describe* a balance sheet. Employers pay you to *build, defend, and act on one under a deadline*. The specific gaps:

College taught	Job actually needs
Ratio definitions	A working 3-statement model that ties out
"Depreciation reduces profit"	The actual Dr/Cr entry in Tally, GST implications
Portfolio theory	Pulling 2M transaction rows in SQL and reconciling
"Tax is 30%"	Filing GSTR-3B, computing MAT, TDS mismatch in 26AS
One right answer	Judgement under ambiguity, defended in an interview

The role map closes the *orientation* gap: MBAs routinely apply to the wrong role, quote the wrong pay band, and fail interviews because they can't name what the desk does hour-to-hour. Knowing the map is itself a screening filter recruiters use.

What "proficient" looks like

A job-ready candidate can, unaided:

1. **Name any role's core deliverable** — "ER analysts publish an initiation report with a target price and a DCF; FP&A owns the monthly variance deck."
2. **Quote a realistic pay band** for their city and level (not a glassdoor fantasy).
3. **Map their own skills to 2-3 target roles** and articulate the entry path.

4. **Pass the role-specific technical screen** — a modelling test for IB, a books-close case for accounting, a SQL screen for product control.

The bar is *specificity*. "I like markets" fails. "I want equity research covering Indian banks because I can already read an RBI-reported NIM and build a provisioning model" passes.

Hands-on: how to actually do it

Below is each major role with its core deliverable, entry path, and a concrete artifact you'd produce.

Accounting — records transactions, closes books, files financials.

```
' Example journal: sale of ₹1,00,000 goods + 18% GST
Dr Debtors (Trade Receivables)      1,18,000
    Cr Sales                          1,00,000
    Cr Output CGST                    9,000
    Cr Output SGST                    9,000
```

Entry path: B.Com/CA-Inter → Accounts Executive → Assistant Manager.

Tax — direct (income tax, TDS, MAT) + indirect (GST). Deliverable: filed GSTR-3B/1, Form 26AS reconciliation.

```
-- reconcile GST purchase register to GSTR-2B
SELECT p.gstin, SUM(p.itc) AS book_itc, SUM(b.itc) AS portal_itc,
       SUM(p.itc) - SUM(b.itc) AS mismatch
FROM purchase_register p
LEFT JOIN gstr2b b ON p.invoice_no = b.invoice_no
GROUP BY p.gstin
HAVING ABS(SUM(p.itc) - SUM(b.itc)) > 1;
```

FP&A (Financial Planning & Analysis) — budgets, forecasts, variance. Deliverable: monthly board deck.

```
=XLOOKUP(A2, Actuals[Cost Centre], Actuals[Amount]) - Budget[Amount]    ' variance
=(ThisMonth-LastMonth)/LastMonth                                       ' MoM %
```

DAX for a rolling forecast:

```
Rolling3M Rev =
CALCULATE( SUM(Sales[Revenue]),
    DATESINPERIOD(Calendar[Date], MAX(Calendar[Date]), -3, MONTH) )
```

Treasury — cash, FX, debt, liquidity. Deliverable: daily cash position, hedge book.

```
# simple FX exposure netting
import pandas as pd
exp = pd.DataFrame({'ccy': ['USD', 'USD', 'EUR'], 'amt': [500000, -200000, 300000]})
net = exp.groupby('ccy')['amt'].sum() # net position to hedge
```

Investment Banking (IB) — raises capital, advises M&A. Deliverable: pitch deck, DCF, LBO model.

```
=NPV(WACC, FCF_range) + TerminalValue/(1+WACC)^n ' enterprise value
```

Equity Research (ER) — covers listed stocks, issues target prices. Deliverable: initiation note.

Credit — assesses borrower repayment ability. Deliverable: credit appraisal memo, rating.

```
=EBITDA/Interest ' interest coverage
=(Total Debt)/EBITDA ' leverage - banks cap ~3.0-3.5x
```

Risk — market/credit/operational risk limits. Deliverable: VaR report, limit monitoring.

```
import numpy as np
returns = np.random.normal(0, 0.02, 1000)
VaR_95 = np.percentile(returns, 5) # 1-day 95% Value at Risk
```

Audit — external (statutory) or internal. Deliverable: audit opinion / control findings.

PE/VC — buys companies (PE) or funds startups (VC). Deliverable: investment committee memo, LBO/cap-table.

Product Control (bank markets desk) — validates trader P&L daily. Deliverable: signed-off daily P&L, P&L explain.

```
SELECT desk, trade_date,
       SUM(mtm_today) - SUM(mtm_yesterday) AS daily_pnl
FROM positions GROUP BY desk, trade_date;
```

Worked example / mini-project

Build your own role-fit scorecard. Reproduce this in Excel with your real numbers.

Role	Core deliverable	Entry path (India)	Fit for you (1-5)	Notes
Accounting	Books close, financials	CA/B.Com → Accts Exec	5	CA-Inter direct fit
Tax	GSTR/ITR filed	CA/CA-Inter → Tax Assoc	5	Strong
FP&A	Variance deck	MBA → FP&A Analyst	5	MBA + Excel
Treasury	Cash/FX position	MBA/CA → Treasury Analyst	4	Learn FX
Credit	Appraisal memo	MBA → Credit Analyst	4	Bank/NBFC
IB	DCF, pitch	Top MBA/CA → Analyst	3	Pedigree-gated
ER	Initiation note	CFA/MBA → Associate	3	Add CFA
Product Control	Daily P&L sign-off	CA/MBA → Analyst	4	GCC hiring

Then compute a weighted score:

```
=SUMPRODUCT(Fit_range, Weight_range)/SUM(Weight_range)
```

Weight by your priorities (pay 40%, growth 30%, fit 30%). The top 2-3 rows become your application targets. This forces the *specificity* recruiters screen for.

Pay bands (approximate, 2026; India in ₹ LPA total; Global in USD base + bonus). GCC = Global Capability Centre in India.

Role	India entry (₹ LPA)	India 5-8 yr (₹ LPA)	Global entry (USD)
Accounting	4-7	12-20	55-75k
Tax	5-8	15-25	60-85k
FP&A	7-12	20-40	70-95k
Treasury	7-12	20-38	70-100k
Credit	6-11	18-35	65-90k
Risk	8-14	22-45	75-110k
Audit (Big 4)	8-12	20-40	60-85k
Product Control	9-15	25-50	75-110k
Equity Research	10-18	30-70	90-140k
IB	15-30	50-1.2cr	110-175k +
PE/VC	18-35	60-1.5cr+	130-200k +

Note: IB/PE bonuses can equal or exceed base; back-office/control roles have tighter, steadier bands.

How it's tested

Role	Interview questions	Practical test
Accounting	"Pass the entry for a prepaid expense." "What's a deferred tax asset?"	Timed: close a trial balance, spot 3 errors
Tax	"Explain reverse charge under GST." "MAT credit mechanism?"	File a mock GSTR-3B; reconcile 26AS
FP&A	"Walk me through your budget vs actual process."	Timed Excel: build a variance bridge, a rolling forecast
Treasury	"How do you hedge a USD payable?"	Cash-flow forecast case
Credit	"Rank these ratios for a lending decision."	Spread a borrower's financials, write a 1-page memo
IB	"Walk me through a DCF." "Why does depreciation flow through 3 statements?"	3-hour LBO/3-statement modelling test
ER	"Pitch me a stock."	Build a model + short thesis on a given company
Product Control	"What's P&L explain?" "T+1 vs T+0?"	SQL screen + a P&L reconciliation case

The single most common practical test across corporate finance is a **timed Excel test** (no internet, 30-90 min). The IB/ER world tests **full modelling from a blank sheet**. Control/product roles increasingly add a **SQL screen**.

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

- **Applying to "finance" generically.** Pros apply to a *named desk* with a matching artifact in hand (a model, a filed return).
- **Quoting Western pay in India (or vice versa).** Know your city's band; overshoot by 2x and you're filtered out, undershoot and you're underpaid for years.
- **Confusing prestige with fit.** IB pays most but is pedigree- and hours-gated. A CA-Inter holder often has a faster, richer path via Audit → Product Control → FP&A than a doomed IB cold-apply.
- **Ignoring the GCC boom.** Bengaluru/Hyderabad/Gurugram GCCs now run real product control, FP&A, and risk for global banks — global-quality work, India base. Underrated entry point.
- **No numbers in interviews.** "I improved reporting" loses. "I cut close from 8 to 5 days by automating a 12-tab reconciliation" wins.
- **Treating audit as a dead end.** Big 4 audit is the single most reliable launchpad in India — it opens Product Control, FP&A, Risk, and internal audit at 2-3x pay within 5 years.

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Time to role-clarity: 1 week. Time to first role: 3-12 months depending on the technical gap.

Phase	Time	Do this
Map	Week 1	Build the role-fit scorecard above; pick 2-3 targets
Skill	Months 1-3	Learn the target's core tool (Excel modelling / SQL / Tally+GST) — later chapters
Proof	Months 2-4	Build 1 portfolio artifact per target role
Apply	Months 3-6	Apply to named desks; use referrals (LinkedIn alumni)

Resources: - **Free:** Corporate Finance Institute intro courses; Aswath Damodaran's valuation lectures (YouTube, free); Mergers & Inquisitions (IB career site); ICAI study material (tax/audit). - **Paid:** WallStreetPrep / Breaking Into Wall Street (IB modelling); CFA (ER/buy-side signal); FRM (risk); CA final (audit/tax — you're already on this). - **Certifications by role:** CA → Audit/Tax/Accounting; CFA → ER/PE/AM; FRM → Risk; NISM → distribution/compliance; MBA → FP&A/Credit/general.

Quick-reference

Role	One-line	Top cert	India entry ₹LPA
Accounting	Keeps the books	CA	4-7
Tax	Files & optimizes tax	CA	5-8
FP&A	Budgets & forecasts	MBA/CFA	7-12
Treasury	Manages cash & FX	MBA/CA	7-12
Credit	Assesses borrowers	MBA/CFA	6-11
Risk	Sets & monitors limits	FRM	8-14
Audit	Verifies statements	CA	8-12
Product Control	Signs off daily P&L	CA	9-15
ER	Covers stocks, target price	CFA	10-18
IB	Raises capital, M&A	MBA/CA	15-30
PE/VC	Invests capital	CFA/MBA	18-35

Rules of thumb: Buy-side pays > sell-side > corporate > assurance, but volatility and hours scale the same way. Big 4 Audit is India's best launchpad. GCCs give global work at India base. Always apply to a *named desk* with a matching *artifact*.

Role-by-Role Skill & Tool Matrix

What it is & where it's used

Every finance job posting is a *disguised skill list*. "Financial Analyst," "Accounts Executive," "Tax Associate" — the titles are vague, but the actual work is a fixed bundle of hard skills and named tools. This chapter is the decoder ring: for each common India-based finance/accounts/tax role, it names the **exact** hard skills, the **specific** tools (with version/module), and the **certifications** that move a resume from the reject pile to the shortlist.

Use this to *target*. Instead of "I'll learn finance," you decide: "I want to be an FP&A Analyst, so I need Excel modelling + Power BI + SQL, and I can skip TallyPrime and GST filing." A CA Inter + MBA candidate can credibly aim at six lanes — R2R accounting, Tax/GST, Audit, FP&A/Analyst, Treasury, and Analytics-leaning Finance — and each rewards a different tool stack.

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

MBA and CA syllabi teach *concepts* (NPV, deferred tax, variance analysis) but not the *tool that executes the concept on Monday morning*. College never made you:

- Build a 3-statement model that ties (BS balances, CF reconciles) under a 45-minute clock.
- File a GSTR-3B on the actual portal or pass a reverse-charge journal in TallyPrime.
- Write `SELECT ... GROUP BY` to pull a revenue cut from a 2-million-row ledger export.
- Reconcile GSTR-2B to the purchase register when 40 invoices mismatch.

Employers pay for *execution under constraint*, not for knowing the definition. The gap this chapter closes: mapping each concept you already know to the **named artifact** an employer will hand you and say "do this."

What "proficient" looks like

The concrete bar, by role — what a job-ready person does **unaided**:

Role	Proficiency bar (does this without help)
Accounts Executive (R2R)	Passes month-end journals (accruals, prepaid, depreciation), reconciles bank & vendor ledgers, closes books in TallyPrime/SAP, produces trial balance
Tax/GST Associate	Files GSTR-1, 3B, does 2B reconciliation, computes TDS & advance tax, handles ITC eligibility calls
FP&A / Financial Analyst	Builds/updates 3-statement model, variance (budget vs actual) decks, forecasts, sensitivity tables; Power BI dashboard
Audit Associate	Vouching/verification, sampling, ratio analytics, drafts working papers, tests internal controls
Treasury/Banking Analyst	Cash-flow forecasting, working-capital metrics, forex/interest exposure, covenant tracking
Finance Data Analyst	SQL pulls, Python/pandas cleaning, DAX measures, automates a recurring MIS

Hands-on: how to actually do it

The universal skill matrix — the spine of the chapter. "★" = must-have, "○" = edge:

Skill / Tool	R2R Acct	Tax/GST	FP&A	Audit	Treasury	Data Analyst
Excel (advanced: XLOOKUP, INDEX/MATCH, pivots)	★	★	★	★	★	★
Financial modelling (3-statement, DCF)	○		★	○	★	○
TallyPrime	★	★		○	○	
SAP FICO / Oracle / Zoho Books	★	○	○	○	○	
GST portal + Income-tax portal	○	★		○		
SQL	○		★	○	○	★
Power BI / Tableau (DAX)	○		★	○	○	★
Python (pandas)			○	○		★
Ind AS / IFRS knowledge	★	○	★	★	○	
Certification signal	CA / CMA	CA + GST cert	CFA / FMVA	CA / ACCA	CFA / Treasury (ACT)	Any + BI cert

Excel — the formulas every role is tested on:

```
=XLOOKUP(A2, Ledger[VendorCode], Ledger[Balance], "Not found")
=SUMIFS(Amount, Date, ">="&DATE(2026,4,1), Date, "<="&DATE(2026,6,30), GL, "5*")
=INDEX(Data, MATCH(1,(Data[Acct]=H2)*(Data[Period]=I2),0),3) ' Ctrl+Shift+Enter (legacy)
=IFERROR(Sales/LAGyear-1, "n/a") ' growth %
```

SQL — a revenue cut an analyst writes daily:

```
SELECT  region,
        DATE_TRUNC('month', invoice_date) AS mth,
        SUM(taxable_value)                AS net_rev,
        SUM(taxable_value * 0.18)         AS gst_est
FROM    sales_invoices
WHERE   invoice_date >= '2026-04-01'
        AND status = 'POSTED'
GROUP BY region, DATE_TRUNC('month', invoice_date)
HAVING SUM(taxable_value) > 100000
ORDER BY net_rev DESC;
```

Python — GSTR-2B vs purchase-register reconciliation (the classic tax test):


```
import pandas as pd
books = pd.read_excel("purchase_register.xlsx")
gstr2b = pd.read_excel("gstr2b.xlsx")
recon = books.merge(gstr2b, on="invoice_no", how="outer",
                    suffixes=("_books", "_2b"), indicator=True)
recon["itc_diff"] = recon["igst_books"].fillna(0) - recon["igst_2b"].fillna(0)
mismatch = recon[(recon["_merge"] != "both") | (recon["itc_diff"].abs() > 1)]
mismatch.to_excel("itc_mismatch.xlsx", index=False)
```

DAX — Power BI measures an FP&A dashboard needs:

```
Net Revenue = SUM(Sales[TaxableValue])
YoY % = DIVIDE([Net Revenue] - CALCULATE([Net Revenue], SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR('Date'[Date])),
               CALCULATE([Net Revenue], SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR('Date'[Date])))
Budget Variance = [Net Revenue] - [Budget]
```

TallyPrime click-path (month-end accrual): Gateway of Tally → Vouchers → F7 (Journal) → Dr *Rent Expense* ₹50,000 → Cr *Rent Payable* ₹50,000 → narration → Ctrl+A to save.

GST portal path (file GSTR-3B): gst.gov.in → Login → Returns Dashboard → select period → GSTR-3B "Prepare Online" → fill 3.1 (outward), 4 (ITC from 2B) → Save → Proceed to Pay → Offset liability → File with DSC/EVC.

Worked example / mini-project

Target role: FP&A Analyst. Deliverable: a Q1 FY27 budget-vs-actual pack. Reproduce with these numbers:

Line (₹ lakh)	Budget	Actual	Variance	Var %
Revenue	1,200	1,140	(60)	-5.0%
COGS	720	700	20	+2.8% (fav)
Gross Profit	480	440	(40)	-8.3%
Employee cost	180	195	(15)	-8.3%
Other opex	120	118	2	+1.7%
EBITDA	180	127	(53)	-29.4%

Steps: (1) Import both columns into Excel, **Variance = Actual - Budget**, **Var% = Variance/Budget**. (2) Flag any line where **ABS(Var%) > 10%** with **=IF(ABS(E2)>0.1,"⚠ Investigate","")**. (3) Root-cause: EBITDA missed by ₹53L driven by a ₹60L revenue shortfall + ₹15L staff overrun. (4) Load into Power BI, add the **YoY %** and **Budget Variance** DAX measures above, build a waterfall visual. (5) One-slide narrative: "Revenue miss (volume, not price) is the EBITDA driver; hiring ran ahead of plan." That five-step artifact is *exactly* what an FP&A screen asks you to produce.

How it's tested

Role	Interview questions	Practical / assessment test
R2R Acct	"Journal for prepaid insurance?" "Bank reco steps?"	Timed: close a mini trial balance in Tally / pass 10 adjusting entries
Tax/GST	"ITC blocked u/s 17(5)?" "RCM on which services?"	Reconcile a GSTR-2B vs register file; compute a 3B liability
FP&A	"Walk me through linking the 3 statements." "How does ₹100 depreciation flow?"	45-min timed model build; budget-variance case
Audit	"Assertions you test for revenue?" "Sampling method?"	Vouch a sample set; spot the misstatement in given ledgers
Data Analyst	"Difference between WHERE and HAVING?"	Live SQL screen (HackerRank); build a dashboard from a CSV

The "₹100 depreciation" question is the FP&A gatekeeper: *Income statement* – 100 → *net income* – $100 \times (1 - \text{tax})$; *Cash flow* add back +100; *Balance sheet* PP&E – 100, cash +tax shield, retained earnings –net income — and it must balance. Know it cold.

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

- **Hardcoding numbers inside formulas.** Pros keep all assumptions in a separate blue-font input cell; formulas reference cells only.
- **A model that doesn't tie.** Amateurs "plug" the balance sheet. Pros build a `Balance check = Assets – (Liab + Equity)` row that must read 0; if not, the CF is wrong.
- **Confusing ITC eligibility.** Blocked credits (u/s 17(5): motor vehicles, personal-use, works contract) get claimed by mistake. Pros reconcile to 2B first, never to the invoice alone.
- **SQL without GROUP BY discipline** — selecting non-aggregated columns; pros put every non-aggregate in `GROUP BY`.
- **Listing tools you can't demo.** Never write "SAP" if you can only spell it. Interviewers ask module-level questions (FICO vs MM).
- **Ignoring Ind AS in accounting roles** — e.g., recognising revenue on invoice date instead of per Ind AS 115 performance obligation.

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Skill	Time to job-ready	Resource (free → paid)
Advanced Excel	3–4 weeks	ExcelJet cheat-sheet (free) → Chandoo; Microsoft Learn
Financial modelling	6–8 weeks	Aswath Damodaran (free, NYU) → CFI FMVA (paid)
TallyPrime	2–3 weeks	Tally Education free videos → Tally certification
GST/tax practice	4 weeks	GSTN free tutorials + ICAI GST module; use the portal sandbox
SQL	3–4 weeks	SQLBolt / Mode SQL tutorial (free) → HackerRank SQL badge
Power BI (DAX)	3–4 weeks	Microsoft Learn (free) → PL-300 certification
Python/pandas	6 weeks	Kaggle "pandas" (free) → DataCamp

Certifications that actually signal, by lane: **CA / CMA** (accounting-tax), **CFA / FMVA** (analyst-FP&A), **ACCA** (global audit), **PL-300** (BI), **ACT** (treasury). Your CA Inter + MBA already covers the accounting-concept base — spend money only on the *tool* certs (FMVA, PL-300) that your degrees don't prove.

Quick-reference

```
Excel:  =XLOOKUP(lookup, arr, return, "NA") | =SUMIFS(sum, crit_rng, crit)
        Balance check row must = 0
SQL:    SELECT col, AGG(x) FROM t WHERE ... GROUP BY col HAVING AGG(x)>n
DAX:    YoY% = DIVIDE([M]-CALCULATE([M],SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR(Date[Date])), prior)
Tally:  F7 journal | F5 payment | Alt+G quick-nav | Ctrl+A save
GST:    3B = 3.1 outward + 4 ITC → offset → file (DSC/EVC); reconcile 2B first
Depn ₹100 flow: IS -100→NI -100(1-t); CF +100; BS PP&E-100, cash+shield, RE-NI
Cert by lane: R2R→CA/CMA | FP&A→CFA/FMVA | Audit→ACCA | BI→PL-300 | Treasury→ACT
```

Targeting rule: pick ONE column of the matrix, master its ★ rows, get its one tool-cert, and build one reproducible artifact (a model, a reco, a dashboard). That column — not "finance" in general — is what you apply for.

The core toolkit every finance pro needs

You cannot learn every tool, and you should not try. There is a priority order that maps to how much of your day each tool touches and how quickly it pays back. Learn them in this sequence: **Excel first (non-negotiable)** → **a data layer (SQL / BI / Python, pick one deeply)** → **domain tools (ERP like Tally/SAP, the GST portal, an FP&A/planning tool)**. Go deep where your role lives; stay literate everywhere else. This chapter shows you the actual formulas, queries, and click-paths — not adjectives about them.

What it is & where it's used

Layer	Tools	Roles that live here
1. Spreadsheet	Excel, Google Sheets	Every finance role, without exception
2. Data	SQL, Power BI/Tableau, Python (pandas)	FP&A, data-heavy analyst, treasury, revenue/RevOps finance
3. Domain	TallyPrime, SAP/Oracle, GST portal, Zoho/QuickBooks, planning tools (Anaplan, Cube)	Accounts payable/receivable, audit, tax, controllership, statutory compliance

A day-1 accounts executive in an Indian SME lives in **Tally + Excel + GST portal**. An FP&A analyst at a mid-cap lives in **Excel + Power BI + SQL**. A Big 4 audit associate lives in **Excel + the client's ERP + CaseWare/IDEA**. Same toolkit, different depth dial.

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

Your MBA taught you *what* a contribution margin is and *why* WACC matters. It did not make you build a 12-tab rolling forecast that ties out to the penny, write a `GROUP BY` to reconcile 40,000 invoice lines, or file a GSTR-3B before the 20th. Colleges grade concepts; employers pay for **artifacts produced under a deadline with real, messy data**.

The specific gaps: - **Speed and correctness on dirty data**. Textbooks give clean tables. Reality gives you trailing spaces, ₹ stored as text, and duplicate vendor codes. - **Auditability**. A pro's model can be checked by someone else. College spreadsheets are write-once. - **Tool fluency = throughput**. The person who does keyboard-only Excel and writes a SQL join does in 20 minutes what a manual analyst does in a day.

Closing this gap is the single highest-ROI thing you can do before your first role.

What "proficient" looks like

The bar employers actually test for, per layer:

- **Excel (must clear this to be hireable)**: builds a model with no hardcoded numbers inside formulas, uses `XLOOKUP / INDEX-MATCH`, `SUMIFS`, `IF / IFS`, absolute vs relative references (\$), pivot tables, and a basic three-statement or cash-flow linkage. Navigates with keyboard (Alt keystrokes, `Ctrl+Arrow`, `F4`). Knows why circular references break a model.
- **Data (pick one deeply)**: writes a multi-table `JOIN` with `GROUP BY` and a filter, OR builds a Power BI report with a DAX measure and a slicer, OR loads a CSV in pandas and does a `groupby().agg()`. You do

not need all three — you need one you can defend in an interview.

- **Domain:** for accounts/tax roles — posts correct journal entries, runs a Tally ledger and GST report, and files/reconciles a GST return (GSTR-2B vs purchase register). For FP&A — owns a budget-vs-actual variance pack.

Hands-on: how to actually do it

Excel — the formulas that earn their keep

```
# Modern lookup – replaces VLOOKUP; searches any direction, handles "not found"
=XLOOKUP(A2, Vendors[Code], Vendors[Name], "Not found")

# Conditional sum across multiple criteria (the FP&A workhorse)
=SUMIFS(Sales[Amount], Sales[Region], "South", Sales[Month], ">="&DATE(2026,4,1))

# Robust lookup that survives inserted columns
=INDEX(Price[Rate], MATCH(A2, Price[SKU], 0))

# Tiered logic without nested IFs
=IFS(B2>=1000000,"Large", B2>=100000,"Mid", TRUE,"Small")

# Clean dirty numbers stored as text with stray spaces / ₹ symbols
=VALUE(SUBSTITUTE(SUBSTITUTE(A2,"₹","")," ",""))

# Spill a unique, sorted list (dynamic arrays, Excel 365)
=SORT(UNIQUE(Sales[Customer]))
```

F4 toggles \$ anchoring — A\$1 , \$A1 , \$A\$1 . Lock your assumption cells; leave calculation cells relative. That single discipline separates an auditable model from a broken one.

SQL — reconcile and aggregate at scale

```
-- Sales by region for Q1 FY26-27, only regions above a ₹10L threshold
SELECT r.region_name,
       SUM(s.amount)      AS total_sales,
       COUNT(*)           AS invoice_count
FROM   sales s
JOIN   regions r ON r.region_id = s.region_id
WHERE  s.invoice_date BETWEEN '2026-04-01' AND '2026-06-30'
GROUP BY r.region_name
HAVING SUM(s.amount) > 1000000
ORDER BY total_sales DESC;

-- Find purchase invoices in your books but NOT in GSTR-2B (mismatch hunt)
SELECT p.invoice_no, p.gstin, p.taxable_value
FROM   purchase_register p
LEFT   JOIN gstr2b g ON g.invoice_no = p.invoice_no
                AND g.gstin      = p.gstin
WHERE  g.invoice_no IS NULL;
```

`LEFT JOIN ... WHERE right IS NULL` is the anti-join — the core pattern for every reconciliation you will ever do.

Python (pandas) — when data outgrows a spreadsheet

```
import pandas as pd

df = pd.read_csv("sales_fy26.csv", parse_dates=["invoice_date"])
df["amount"] = pd.to_numeric(df["amount"], errors="coerce")  # coerce dirty text to NaN

# Region-wise revenue and average ticket
summary = (df.groupby("region")
            .agg(total=("amount", "sum"),
                 avg_ticket=("amount", "mean"),
                 invoices=("amount", "count"))
            .sort_values("total", ascending=False))

# Reconcile books vs portal via a merge (same idea as SQL anti-join)
mismatch = books.merge(portal, on=["invoice_no", "gstin"],
                       how="left", indicator=True)
mismatch = mismatch[mismatch["_merge"] == "left_only"]
print(summary)
```

DAX — for Power BI reports

```
Total Sales    = SUM(Sales[Amount])
Sales LY       = CALCULATE([Total Sales], SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR('Date'[Date]))
YoY Growth %   = DIVIDE([Total Sales] - [Sales LY], [Sales LY])
```

TallyPrime + GST portal — the domain click-path

- **Post a purchase in Tally:** Gateway of Tally → Vouchers → F9 (Purchase) → select party → item → tax ledgers (CGST/SGST or IGST) auto-compute → **Ctrl+A** to save.
- **See a ledger:** Gateway → Display More Reports → Account Books → Ledger.
- **GST filing:** log in at gst.gov.in → Returns Dashboard → pick period → **GSTR-1** (outward supplies) → **GSTR-3B** (summary + tax payment) → offset liability from Electronic Credit/Cash Ledger → file with DSC/EVC. Reconcile **GSTR-2B** (auto-drafted ITC) against your purchase register *before* claiming input credit.

Journal entries — the language underneath every tool

Transaction	Account	Dr (₹)	Cr (₹)
Credit purchase, goods ₹1,00,000 + 18% GST	Purchases A/c	1,00,000	
	Input CGST A/c	9,000	
	Input SGST A/c	9,000	
	To Vendor A/c		1,18,000
Salary accrued	Salary A/c	50,000	
	To Salary Payable		50,000

Worked example / mini-project

Build a budget-vs-actual variance pack for "Kaveri Traders" (FY 2026-27, Q1).

1. **Data.** Two sheets: **Budget** and **Actuals**, columns = Cost Centre, Month, Amount. Say budgeted opex ₹42,00,000; actual ₹45,60,000.
2. **Pull actuals against budget** with a keyed lookup: **excel** `=SUMIFS(Actuals[Amount], Actuals[CostCentre], A2, Actuals[Month], B2)`
3. **Variance and %:** **excel** `=Actual - Budget` # ₹3,60,000 unfavourable `=(Actual - Budget)/Budget` # 8.6% over
4. **Flag the outliers** so a manager reads it in 5 seconds: **excel** `=IF(ABS(VarPct)>0.10, "REVIEW", "OK")`
5. **Summarise** with a pivot: rows = Cost Centre, values = Sum of Variance, then sort descending. Marketing is ₹2,10,000 over on a ₹5,00,000 budget (42%) — that is your headline.
6. **One-line narrative:** "Q1 opex ran 8.6% (₹3.6L) over budget, driven by Marketing (+42%) on an unplanned campaign; travel and utilities were on-plan."

That deliverable — numbers that tie out, outliers flagged, a one-line story — is exactly what an FP&A hiring manager wants to see.

How it's tested

Role	Interview questions	Practical test
FP&A analyst	"VLOOKUP vs INDEX-MATCH vs XLOOKUP — when each?" "How do you avoid circular refs in a model?"	Timed Excel test (30–60 min): given raw sales data, build a pivot, compute variance %, flag exceptions. No internet.
Data/BI analyst	"Explain the anti-join." "INNER vs LEFT JOIN." "What does GROUP BY return?"	Live SQL screen on HackerRank/DataLemur: write a query against a schema they hand you.
Accounts / tax	"Pass the journal entry for a credit purchase with GST." "GSTR-2A vs 2B?"	"Close these books" case: post vouchers in Tally, produce a trial balance, reconcile 2B vs purchase register.
Controllership	"Walk me through a 3-statement model."	Take-home model with a broken link to fix.

Assume the practical test is unaided and timed. Prepare by *doing*, not watching.

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

- **Hardcoding numbers inside formulas** (`=B2*1.18`). Pros put the 18% in a labelled assumption cell and reference it. Auditable, changeable.
- **VLOOKUP breaking on inserted columns.** Use `XLOOKUP` or `INDEX-MATCH` .
- **Trusting dirty data.** Numbers stored as text silently break `SUMIFS` . Run `=ISNUMBER()` , use `VALUE()` / `TRIM()` , watch for the green triangle.
- **SELECT * in SQL** and forgetting `GROUP BY` non-aggregated columns. Name columns; aggregate deliberately.
- **Claiming GST input credit before 2B reconciliation** — a real compliance error that triggers notices. Always reconcile first.
- **No version control on models.** Pros date filenames (`Model_2026-07-03_v3.xlsx`) and freeze the assumptions tab.
- **Learning three tools shallowly.** One deep skill beats three you can't defend under questioning.

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Skill	Time to job-ready	Resources
Excel (core)	4–6 weeks, daily practice	Microsoft Excel help; ExcelJet cheat-sheet; Chandoo.org; <i>Excel to the max</i> problems. Cert (optional): Microsoft Office Specialist – Excel Associate .
SQL	3–4 weeks	Mode SQL Tutorial (free), SQLBolt, DataLemur, LeetCode Database.
Power BI	3–4 weeks	Microsoft Learn (free); PL-300 cert is well-recognised in India.
Python/pandas	6–8 weeks	Kaggle "Pandas" micro-course (free); <i>Python for Data Analysis</i> (McKinney).
Tally + GST	2–3 weeks	TallyEducation.com; GSTN free videos; practise on the GST offline/sandbox . Cert: Tally ACE/Professional .

Realistic total to a strong finance-toolkit baseline: ~**3 months** of focused daily practice alongside your CA prep. Sequence: nail Excel → add SQL *or* Power BI → layer Tally + GST (which your CA syllabus already reinforces).

Quick-reference

Need	Tool	Formula / command
Directional lookup	Excel	<code>=XLOOKUP(key, lookup_col, return_col, "NA")</code>
Multi-criteria sum	Excel	<code>=SUMIFS(sum, c1, v1, c2, v2)</code>
Robust lookup	Excel	<code>=INDEX(ret, MATCH(key, look, 0))</code>
Clean text→number	Excel	<code>=VALUE(SUBSTITUTE(A2,"",""))</code>
Anchor references	Excel	<code>F4 → \$A\$1</code>
Aggregate w/ filter	SQL	<code>SELECT col, SUM(x) ... GROUP BY col HAVING ...</code>
Find non-matches	SQL	<code>LEFT JOIN ... WHERE b.id IS NULL</code>
Group summary	pandas	<code>df.groupby("k").agg(total=("x", "sum"))</code>
YoY measure	DAX	<code>CALCULATE([Sales], SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR('Date'[Date]))</code>
GST input credit	Portal	Reconcile GSTR-2B vs purchase register <i>before</i> claiming
GST monthly file	Portal	GSTR-1 → GSTR-3B → offset → file (by 11th / 20th)
Purchase entry	Tally	<code>F9 → party → item → tax ledgers → Ctrl+A</code>

Standard GST rates: 0%, 5%, 12%, 18%, 28%. **Filing dates:** GSTR-1 by 11th, GSTR-3B by 20th of the following month (monthly filers). Keep this card next to your keyboard for your first 90 days.

Certifications Decoded

What it is & where it's used

A finance certification is a **paid signal**. It tells an employer "this person can already do the job at bar X" so they don't have to test you from scratch. Eight matter for an India-based candidate: **CA, CFA, FMVA, CPA, ACCA, FPAC, NISM, FRM**. Each maps to a *different* role — stacking the wrong two wastes 2-3 years.

Cert	Body	What it signals	Primary roles
CA	ICAI (India)	Audit, tax, statutory accounting, Indian GAAP/Ind-AS	Statutory audit, tax, controller, CFO track
CFA	CFA Institute (US)	Investment analysis, valuation, portfolio mgmt	Equity research, AMC, PE/VC, IB
FMVA	CFI (online)	3-statement + DCF modeling in Excel	FP&A, corporate finance, analyst, startup finance
CPA	AICPA (US)	US GAAP, US audit/tax, SOX	US accounting, MNC controllership, Big-4 US desk
ACCA	ACCA (UK)	IFRS, global audit/reporting	MNC finance, UK/Gulf/EU roles, shared services
FPAC	AFP (US)	Financial planning & analysis discipline	Senior FP&A, budgeting, business finance
NISM	SEBI (India)	Regulatory license to <i>operate</i> in Indian markets	Mutual fund distributor, RA, dealer, compliance
FRM	GARP (US)	Market/credit/operational risk quant	Risk mgmt at banks, treasury, model validation

NISM is not a "career" cert — it's a **legal licence**. You literally cannot sell a mutual fund or work as a Registered Investment Adviser in India without the relevant module. The others are competitive differentiators.

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

An MBA Finance teaches you *frameworks* — WACC, CAPM, Porter, DuPont. Employers pay for *execution*: can you actually build the DCF, close the books, file the GST return, or size a Value-at-Risk? That is the gap.

- **College taught** "cost of equity = $R_f + \beta(R_m - R_f)$ ". **Job needs** you to pull β from Bloomberg, unlever/relever it for a private target, and defend the 4.5% equity-risk-premium you plugged in.
- **College taught** "revenue is recognised when earned". **Job needs** you to pass the Ind-AS 115 five-step entry, reconcile it to GSTR-3B, and explain the deferred-revenue movement to the auditor.
- **College taught** portfolio theory. **Job needs** the NISM licence before you're allowed to *touch* a client account.

Certifications close this because their exams and case components are written by practitioners, not academics. CFA Level 2 makes you value a company item-by-item. CA articleship forces 3 years of real audit

files. FMVA's final is "here's a raw 10-K, build the model." That practitioner bar is exactly what recruiters screen for.

What "proficient" looks like

The bar is not "I passed." It is "I can do the deliverable unaided, on a deadline."

Cert	A proficient holder can, alone...
CA	Finalise a company's books, pass Ind-AS entries, file ITR-6 + GSTR-9, sign a tax audit
CFA	Build a DCF + comparables, write a research note with a target price and a BUY/SELL
FMVA	Turn a 10-K into a linked 3-statement model + DCF + sensitivity in < 1 day
CPA	Prepare US-GAAP financials, run a SOX control test, file a corporate return
ACCA	Produce IFRS consolidated accounts with FX translation and NCI
FPAC	Own a rolling forecast, variance bridge, and driver-based budget
NISM	Legally advise/sell the product + explain suitability and disclosures
FRM	Compute 1-day 99% VaR, run a stress test, validate a credit model

Notice the overlap: **CA, CFA-L2 and FMVA all demand a working DCF.** That's your fastest transferable skill — build it once, it pays across three certs.

Hands-on: how to actually do it

The single most-tested deliverable across CA, CFA, FMVA, FPAC and CPA is a **discounted-cash-flow valuation**. Here is the copy-usable core.

Step 1 — Free Cash Flow to Firm, in Excel. Lay out years in columns C:G.

```
FCFF = EBIT*(1-Tax) + D&A - CapEx - ΔNWC
```

```
' C10 = EBIT, C11 = tax rate, C12 = D&A, C13 = CapEx, C14 = change in NWC  
=C10*(1-$C$11)+C12-C13-C14
```

Step 2 — WACC.

```
' E = equity value, D = debt, Re = cost of equity, Rd = cost of debt, t = tax  
=(E/(E+D))*Re + (D/(E+D))*Rd*(1-t)
```

Step 3 — Discount factor and PV of each year.

```
' row 20 = FCFF, $B$3 = WACC, C1:G1 = period number 1..5  
=C20/(1+$B$3)^C1
```

Step 4 — Terminal value (Gordon growth) and enterprise value.

```
' G20 = final-year FCFF, g in B4, WACC in B3
=G20*(1+$B$4)/($B$3-$B$4) ' terminal value at year 5
=NPV($B$3,C20:G20)+ (TV/(1+$B$3)^5) ' enterprise value
```

Step 5 — Pull the actuals for the model. In practice you don't type financials by hand; you query a warehouse.

```
SELECT fiscal_year,
       revenue,
       ebit,
       depreciation,
       capex,
       (current_assets - current_liab) AS nwc
FROM   financials
WHERE  ticker = 'RELIANCE'
ORDER BY fiscal_year;
```

Step 6 — Sensitivity in Python (what FMVA and FP&A interviews ask you to automate):

```
import numpy as np
def ev(fcff, wacc, g):
    pv = sum(cf/(1+wacc)**(i+1) for i, cf in enumerate(fcff))
    tv = fcff[-1]*(1+g)/(wacc-g)
    return pv + tv/(1+wacc)**len(fcff)

fcff = [120, 138, 152, 165, 176] # ₹ crore
for w in (0.10, 0.11, 0.12):
    print([round(ev(fcff, w, g)) for g in (0.03, 0.04, 0.05)])
```

For the CA/CPA/ACCA accounting bar, proficiency is passing correct entries. Revenue recognised in advance (Ind-AS 115 / IFRS 15):

Event	Dr	Cr	Amount (₹)
Cash received before delivery	Bank	Contract Liability (deferred rev)	1,18,000
GST on advance	Contract Liability	Output CGST/SGST	18,000
Service delivered	Contract Liability	Revenue	1,00,000

For NISM/FPAC dashboards, a portfolio-return DAX measure:

```
Portfolio Return :=
DIVIDE(
    SUMX(Holdings, Holdings[MarketValue] - Holdings[CostBasis]),
    SUM(Holdings[CostBasis])
)
```

Worked example / mini-project

Value a mid-cap and decide the cert-appropriate output. Company: revenue ₹800 cr, EBIT margin 20%, tax 25%, D&A ₹40 cr, CapEx ₹60 cr, ΔNWC ₹15 cr, WACC 11%, terminal g 4%.

Year-1 FCFF:

EBIT	= 800 × 20%	= ₹160 cr
NOPAT	= 160 × (1-0.25)	= ₹120 cr
FCFF	= 120 + 40 - 60 - 15	= ₹85 cr

Grow FCFF ~8%/yr → [85, 92, 99, 107, 116]. Terminal value:

TV	= 116 × 1.04 / (0.11 - 0.04)	= ₹1,723 cr
PV(TV)	= 1723 / 1.11 ⁵	= ₹1,022 cr
PV(explicit 5 yrs)	≈ ₹364 cr	
Enterprise Value	≈ ₹1,386 cr	

Now the cert lens on the *same* number: - **CFA candidate** writes: "EV ₹1,386 cr; less net debt ₹200 cr → equity ₹1,186 cr; ÷ 10 cr shares = ₹118 target vs ₹95 market → **BUY, 24% upside.**" - **FMVA/FP&A candidate** wires it into a 3-statement model and runs a 3×3 WACC-vs-g data table. - **CA/CPA candidate** ignores valuation and instead ensures the ₹85 cr cash flow ties to the audited cash-flow statement and the deferred-tax working.

Same math, three deliverables — that's why one skill funds three certs.

How it's tested

Interviews split into a **verbal round** and a **practical assessment**. Prepare for both.

Verbal questions you will get: - "Walk me through a DCF." (CFA/FMVA/FP&A) — 90-second fluent answer expected. - "Why does an increase in NWC *reduce* free cash flow?" - "Deferred tax asset vs liability — give me a live example." (CA/CPA/ACCA) - "Client wants a small-cap fund — what NISM suitability check do you run?" - "Define 99% 1-day VaR and its biggest limitation." (FRM)

Practical assessments actually used:

Role	The real test
FP&A / FMVA	Timed 60-min Excel: raw trial balance → linked P&L + variance bridge
Equity research (CFA)	"Value this listed company overnight, present tomorrow"
Audit/Accounting (CA)	"Close these books" case: adjusting entries + finalisation
Data-finance	SQL screen: window functions, joins, a running total
Risk (FRM)	Compute VaR on a given return series in Excel/Python

The Excel test is where MBAs fail: **no mouse-hunting**. They watch whether you flow-navigate (`Ctrl+↓` , `Alt+=` , `F4` to lock refs) and whether every number is a *formula*, never a *hardcode*.

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

- **Hardcoding numbers into formulas.** Pros put every assumption in a labelled blue-font input cell and reference it. Auditors reject models they can't trace.
- **Stacking overlapping certs.** CA + ACCA is ~80% redundant for an India candidate. Pros pick *complementary* pairs (CA + CFA, or CA + FMVA).
- **Chasing CFA charter before CA/job.** CFA needs 4,000 hrs work experience to charter — collect the letters *don't* just pass exams.
- **Treating NISM as optional.** Working unlicensed in an AMC/advisory is a SEBI violation. Get the module *before* the offer.
- **Circular references left broken** in the interest-on-debt loop — pros enable iterative calc (File → Options → Formulas → *Enable iterative calculation*) and know why.
- **Round numbers with no source.** Every driver should trace to a filing, a query, or a documented assumption.

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Realistic time-to-proficiency and ROI (India context):

Cert	Time	Cost (₹)	Salary lift signal
NISM (per module)	2-3 wks	1,500-2,000	Enables the job; low direct lift
FMVA	2-4 months	~40,000	Strong for FP&A/analyst; fastest ROI
FPAC	4-6 months	~1.2 L	Senior FP&A credibility
CFA (all 3)	2.5-4 yrs	~3-4 L	High for research/AMC/IB
FRM (both parts)	1-1.5 yrs	~1.5 L	High for bank risk roles
CA	4-5 yrs	~2-3 L	Highest base for audit/tax/controller
CPA (US)	1-1.5 yrs	~3.5 L	MNC/US-desk premium
ACCA	2-3 yrs	~3 L	Gulf/UK/IFRS roles

Recommended sequence for you (MBA + CA-Inter in progress): 1. **Finish CA** — it's your deepest moat; don't abandon a sunk 2-3 years. 2. **Add FMVA now** (parallel, cheap, fast) — instantly employable for FP&A while you article. 3. **Then CFA** *only if* you want research/AMC/PE; else **FPAC** for a corporate-finance track. 4. NISM modules on-demand the moment a market-facing role requires one.

Resources: CFI (FMVA courses + free Excel guides), Mercer/Kaplan (CFA), ICAI BoS portal + free study material (CA), AFP.org (FPAC), NISM.ac.in (registration + free workbooks), GARP.org (FRM), Aswath Damodaran's free NYU valuation lectures and datasets (the single best free resource for all valuation-based certs).

Quick-reference

Item	Value / formula
FCFF	$\text{EBIT} \times (1-t) + \text{D\&A} - \text{CapEx} - \Delta \text{NWC}$
WACC	$(E/V)R_e + (D/V)R_d(1-t)$
Terminal value	$\text{FCFF} \times (1+g) / (WACC-g)$
CAPM cost of equity	$R_f + \beta(R_m - R_f)$
Excel: lock reference	F4
Excel: sum column	Alt + =
Excel: lookup	=XLOOKUP(key, lookup_range, return_range)
CFA charter needs	3 exams + 4,000 hrs experience
NISM =	SEBI <i>licence</i> , not a differentiator
Best India pair	CA + FMVA (accounting + modeling)
Fastest ROI cert	FMVA (2-4 months, ~₹40k)
Highest base	CA (audit/tax/controller/CFO track)

Your MBA-Finance starting point: strengths & gaps

What it is & where it's used

This chapter is a personal audit — a brutally honest map of what you already sell in an interview versus what you have to build before Monday of your first job. Your profile is specific and, frankly, strong: **MBA Finance + NISM Series XV (Research Analyst) + ~2 years on an F&O / derivatives desk + CA Intermediate in progress**. That combination signals markets fluency, valuation literacy, and — once CA is done — accounting and tax depth that most candidates never reach.

But a resume is not a skill set. Employers in India hire for *tasks*: build the three-statement model, reconcile the GST 2B, write the SQL that feeds the MIS deck, close the books by the 5th. Roles that map to your profile:

Role family	What they actually want daily	Your fit today
Equity/credit research, buy-side	Valuation models, thesis notes, screening	Strong
FP&A / Corporate finance	Excel modeling, variance analysis, BI dashboards	Partial
Financial / management accounting	Journal entries, close, Tally/ERP, GST/TDS	Gap → closing with CA
Risk / treasury / derivatives ops	Greeks, VaR, hedge accounting, position recon	Strong on theory, gap on tooling
Data-driven finance / analytics	SQL, Python, Power BI, automation	Gap

The job is to convert *credentials* into *deliverables*.

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

An MBA teaches you to *reason* about finance — NPV, WACC, CAPM, Porter, capital structure. Employers assume you can reason. What they pay for is *execution under a deadline on their data*. That is the education-to-industry gap, and it has four concrete faces for your profile.

1. **Hands-on Excel modeling.** You know DCF conceptually. Can you build a live, circular-reference-safe three-statement model with a working capital schedule, a debt sweep, and toggles — in 90 minutes, no template? That's the test, and college never times you.
2. **SQL / Python / BI.** Company data lives in databases and ERPs, not textbook tables. FP&A and analytics roles now assume you can pull your own data (`SELECT`), not wait for IT. Python replaces the manual monthly copy-paste.
3. **ERP & practical compliance.** CA *theory* teaches Ind AS and GST law. The job needs you to *pass a GST entry in TallyPrime*, file GSTR-3B on the portal, and reconcile 2B — click by click.
4. **FP&A tooling.** Budget vs actual, rolling forecasts, driver-based models, and a Power BI dashboard the CFO opens on their phone. MBA cases end at the recommendation; the job starts there.

What "proficient" looks like

The bar an employer tests for — what a job-ready person does *unaided*:

- **Excel:** Builds a 3-statement model from a blank sheet; uses `XLOOKUP` , `SUMIFS` , `INDEX/MATCH` , `IFERROR` ; finds and kills a circularity; no hardcoded numbers inside formulas; keyboard-driven (Alt shortcuts, no mouse).
- **SQL:** Writes a multi-table `JOIN` with `GROUP BY` , a window function, and a CTE to answer "top 5 customers by overdue receivables this quarter" without googling syntax.
- **Python:** Reads an Excel/CSV with `pandas` , cleans it, does a `groupby` , and exports a formatted output — turning a 2-hour manual task into a 20-second script.
- **BI:** A Power BI model with a proper date table and 4-5 DAX measures (YoY, YTD, variance %).
- **Compliance/ERP:** Passes purchase/sales entries with correct CGST/SGST/IGST split in Tally, reconciles GSTR-2B to books, computes TDS under the right section.

If you can do these five things cold, you clear ~80% of India finance-role practical screens.

Hands-on: how to actually do it

Leverage your strength first — a derivatives P&L any desk respects, in Excel:

```
Payoff of long call at expiry: =MAX(0, Spot - Strike) - Premium
Long put:                      =MAX(0, Strike - Spot) - Premium
Breakeven (long call):        =Strike + Premium
```

Fill the Excel gap — the formulas that appear in every modeling test:

```
=XLOOKUP(A2, Master[Code], Master[Name], "Not found")
=SUMIFS(Sales[Amt], Sales[Region], "West", Sales[Month], ">=" & DATE(2026, 4, 1))
=IFERROR(INDEX(Rate, MATCH(1, (T=B2)*(Tenor=C2), 0)), 0) 'array match
=NPV(0.11, C5:C14) + C4 'C4 = year-0 cash flow, kept outside NPV
=IRR(C4:C14)
```

Close the SQL gap — the query pattern FP&A lives on:

```

-- Top 5 customers by overdue receivables, current quarter
SELECT c.customer_name,
       SUM(i.amount_due) AS overdue
FROM invoices i
JOIN customers c ON c.id = i.customer_id
WHERE i.due_date < CURRENT_DATE
      AND i.status = 'OPEN'
GROUP BY c.customer_name
ORDER BY overdue DESC
LIMIT 5;

-- Month-on-month revenue with a window function
SELECT month,
       revenue,
       revenue - LAG(revenue) OVER (ORDER BY month) AS mom_change
FROM monthly_revenue;

```

Close the Python gap — kill a recurring manual task:

```

import pandas as pd

df = pd.read_excel("ledger.xlsx", sheet_name="GL")
df["month"] = pd.to_datetime(df["date"]).dt.to_period("M")

summary = (df.groupby(["month", "cost_center"])["amount"]
           .sum()
           .reset_index()
           .pivot(index="cost_center", columns="month", values="amount"))

summary.to_excel("cost_center_MIS.xlsx")

```

Close the BI gap — DAX measures for a variance dashboard:

```

Revenue YTD    = TOTALYTD(SUM(Fact[Revenue]), 'Date'[Date])
Revenue LY     = CALCULATE(SUM(Fact[Revenue]), SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR('Date'[Date]))
YoY %         = DIVIDE([Revenue YTD] - [Revenue LY], [Revenue LY])
Bud Variance   = SUM(Fact[Actual]) - SUM(Fact[Budget])

```

Close the compliance gap — an actual GST purchase entry (goods bought within Maharashtra, ₹1,00,000 @ 18%):

Account	Dr (₹)	Cr (₹)
Purchases A/c	1,00,000	
Input CGST @ 9%	9,000	
Input SGST @ 9%	9,000	
To Creditor (ABC Ltd)		1,18,000

TallyPrime path: Gateway of Tally → Vouchers → F9 Purchase → select party → item → GST auto-computes if the ledger's GST rate + place of supply are set. Interstate? The CGST/SGST lines collapse into a single **IGST @ 18% = ₹18,000**.

Worked example / mini-project

Project: One-page FP&A pack for a mid-size distributor, FY 2026-27. Reproduce this end to end — it exercises your gaps and shows off your strengths.

Assume budgeted annual revenue ₹12 crore (₹1 cr/month, flat), actuals below for Q1:

Month	Budget (₹)	Actual (₹)
Apr	1,00,00,000	92,00,000
May	1,00,00,000	1,05,00,000
Jun	1,00,00,000	1,11,00,000

Step 1 — Excel variance:

Variance ₹	=Actual - Budget	'Apr = -8,00,000
Variance %	=(Actual-Budget)/Budget	'Apr = -8.0%
Q1 Actual	=SUM(Actuals)	'=3,08,00,000
Run-rate FY	=AVERAGE(Q1)*12	'=12,32,00,000

Step 2 — SQL for the underlying pull (if data sits in a DB):

```
SELECT DATE_TRUNC('month', invoice_date) AS month, SUM(net_amount) AS actual
FROM sales WHERE invoice_date ≥ '2026-04-01'
GROUP BY 1 ORDER BY 1;
```

Step 3 — Python to auto-build the deck data (from `sales.xlsx`) using the snippet above, exporting a clean pivot.

Step 4 — DAX in Power BI to show `Bud Variance` and `YoY %` as cards with a monthly bar chart.

Result you present: "Q1 revenue is ₹3.08 cr, tracking ₹32 lakh *ahead* of the ₹3 cr budget after a soft April; FY run-rate ₹12.32 cr vs ₹12 cr budget, +2.7%." That one sentence — data-backed, tool-built — is what an FP&A hire is paid to produce.

How it's tested

Indian and global finance interviews increasingly split into a talk round and a *do* round.

Screen	What they hand you	Time
Timed Excel test	Blank sheet + assumptions → build DCF or 3-statement model	60-120 min
SQL screen	Schema + 3-4 questions ("2nd highest salary", "running total")	30-45 min
Case: "close these books"	Trial balance with errors → adjust, produce P&L + BS	60 min
Compliance task	Invoice set → compute GST/TDS, say which return & due date	30 min
Markets round (your home turf)	"Price this option / explain contango / what's your view"	Live

Common interview questions: *Walk me through a DCF. How does depreciation flow through three statements? What's the TDS rate on professional fees? Difference between GSTR-1, 2B, 3B? When would you use INDEX/MATCH over VLOOKUP?* Prepare to **do**, not describe.

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

- **Leading with credentials, not deliverables.** "I have an MBA and NISM" → weak. "I built a 3-statement model and a Power BI variance pack" → hired. Pros open with artifacts.
- **Hardcoding numbers inside Excel formulas.** `=A2*1.18` is a red flag; put 18% in a labeled input cell and reference it. Assumptions live in one colored block.
- **Mouse-driving Excel in a timed test.** Learn Alt-key shortcuts; speed is graded.
- **Treating SQL/Python as "IT's job."** Analysts who pull their own data get promoted; those who raise tickets wait.
- **Confusing CA theory with ERP practice.** Knowing Section 194J ≠ passing the entry in Tally and filing 26Q. Do both.
- **Ignoring reconciliation.** GSTR-2B vs books mismatch is the #1 real-world compliance task; models must tie out to the rupee.
- **Underselling the derivatives edge.** Few finance hires can price an option or explain the Greeks. That's a differentiator — name it.

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Realistic time-to-proficiency assuming ~1 hr/day alongside CA:

Skill	To job-ready	Resource
Excel modeling	3-4 weeks	CFI free Excel courses; Wall Street Prep; Chandoo.org (free)
SQL	3-4 weeks	SQLBolt (free), Mode SQL tutorial, LeetCode DB easy/medium
Python (pandas)	4-6 weeks	Kaggle "pandas" micro-course (free); <i>Python for Data Analysis</i>
Power BI + DAX	2-3 weeks	Microsoft Learn (free); SQLBI.com; DAX Guide
Tally + GST practical	2-3 weeks	Tally EDU free lessons; ICAI GST material (you already have via CA)

Certifications worth it: **Microsoft PL-300 (Power BI Data Analyst)**, **CFI FMVA** (modeling), and finish **CA** — it dominates every other line item. Sequence: Excel → SQL → Power BI → Python, folding Tally/GST practice in parallel with your CA GST paper.

Quick-reference

STRENGTHS to sell: Markets/derivatives · valuation · NISM RA · CA depth (incoming)

GAPS to close: Excel modeling · SQL · Python · Power BI · Tally/GST practical

Excel: =XLOOKUP() =SUMIFS() =INDEX/MATCH =IFERROR() =NPV() =IRR() (inputs in one block)

SQL: SELECT ... JOIN ... GROUP BY ... ; window: LAG() OVER(ORDER BY ...)

Python: pd.read_excel → groupby → pivot → to_excel

DAX: TOTALYTD · SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR · DIVIDE for YoY%

GST: Intra-state = CGST+SGST split · Inter-state = IGST · reconcile 2B to books

Options: Long call P/L = $\text{MAX}(0, S-K)$ - premium ; breakeven = $K + \text{premium}$

One-line self-brief: "MBA + markets desk + CA-in-progress who ships models, dashboards, and clean books — not just opinions." Build three artifacts (a 3-statement model, a Power BI pack, a Tally close) and your gap is closed.

The 90-Day Job-Ready Sprint

What it is & where it's used

This chapter is the operating system for the previous six chapters. It takes the raw skills — Excel modeling, accounting close, GST/TDS compliance, SQL, Python, Power BI/DAX — and sequences them into a **12-week, week-by-week plan** that ends with you being able to sit an interview and a practical test without freezing. The sprint is designed for the reader who has 2–4 focused hours a day (evenings + weekends around CA classes or a current job). It is used by anyone targeting entry-to-junior roles: **Accounts Executive, Finance Analyst, Audit Associate, FP&A Analyst, Tax Associate, Financial/Data Analyst**. The logic is simple: employers don't pay for what you *know*, they pay for what you can *produce unaided by Friday*. Ninety days is enough to build 3–4 portfolio artifacts that prove exactly that.

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

An MBA gives you the *vocabulary* (WACC, DCF, contribution margin) and CA gives you the *rules* (Ind AS, GST law). Neither gives you **throughput** — the muscle memory to open a blank workbook and deliver a working model in 90 minutes, or to reconcile a GSTR-2B against your purchase register before a return deadline.

College teaches	Job requires
"Explain a DCF"	Build a 5-year DCF from a P&L in Excel, sensitivity table included
"Journal entries in theory"	Close a month in Tally, tie out to a trial balance
"GST has 4 slabs"	File GSTR-3B and reconcile ITC from 2B on the portal
"SQL is a query language"	Pull revenue by region for last quarter under time pressure
Solo exams	Deliver a shared model a manager can audit and trust

The gap is **speed, accuracy, and format** — turning knowledge into a clean deliverable someone else can rely on. This sprint closes it by forcing daily reps and weekly shippable outputs.

What "proficient" looks like

The bar at day 90, unaided:

- Build a 3-statement or DCF model in Excel from scratch; no hardcoded numbers inside formulas; every driver on an assumptions tab.
- Perform a bank reconciliation and a month-end close in TallyPrime; produce a trial balance that ties.
- Compute GST liability, reconcile ITC from GSTR-2B, and walk through filing GSTR-3B on the portal.
- Write SELECT queries with JOIN, GROUP BY, and a window function against a real schema.
- Load a CSV in Python/pandas, clean it, and produce a summary; or build a Power BI dashboard with 3–4 DAX measures.
- Talk through each artifact in an interview: what you assumed, why, and what would break it.

Hands-on: how to actually do it

The sprint is four 3-week blocks. Each block ends with **one portfolio artifact**.

Block 1 (Wk 1–3): Excel + Accounting core. The non-negotiable foundation for every finance role.

Wk1: Excel mechanics – XLOOKUP, INDEX/MATCH, SUMIFS, IF logic, pivot tables, absolute refs.
Wk2: Accounting close – journal entries, T-accounts, trial balance, BRS, accruals/prepaids.
Wk3: Build a 3-statement model linking P&L → BS → Cash Flow.

Core Excel reps to drill until automatic:

```
=XLOOKUP(A2, Ledger[Code], Ledger[Name], "Not found")  
=SUMIFS(Amount, Region, "West", Month, "Jun")  
=INDEX(Rate, MATCH(1, (Item=G2)*(Vendor=H2), 0))    ' Ctrl+Shift+Enter or dynamic array  
=IFERROR(Revenue/Prior-1, "n/a")                  ' YoY growth, safe
```

A recurring-revenue driver on the assumptions tab (never type numbers in the P&L):

```
Revenue_Y2 = Revenue_Y1 * (1 + Growth_Rate)    ' Growth_Rate lives in cell $B$4  
Gross_Profit = Revenue * (1 - COGS_pct)
```

Sales-invoice journal entry (India, 18% GST intra-state):

Account	Dr (₹)	Cr (₹)
Debtors / Bank	1,18,000	
To Sales		1,00,000
To Output CGST @9%		9,000
To Output SGST @9%		9,000

Block 2 (Wk 4–6): Tax & compliance in Tally + GST portal. Where accounts/tax roles are won.

TallyPrime click-path to record that same sales invoice: Gateway of Tally → Vouchers → F8 (Sales) → Party A/c name → select Sales ledger → select stock item → GST auto-computes from ledger rates → Ctrl+A to save.

GST liability logic you must be able to compute cold:

```
Output GST (on sales)      = 90,000  
Less: Input Tax Credit     = 62,000    (from GSTR-2B, only invoices that appear)  
Net GST payable in cash   = 28,000    → paid via GSTR-3B, Table 3.1 + 6.1
```

Reconcile ITC in Excel before filing — match purchase register to GSTR-2B:

```
=XLOOKUP([@GSTIN&Invoice], TwoB[Key], TwoB[TaxValue], "MISSING in 2B")
```

Any "MISSING in 2B" row = ITC you cannot claim this month. TDS on professional fees (Sec 194J, 10%):

Account	Dr (₹)	Cr (₹)
Professional Fees	50,000	
To TDS Payable (194J)		5,000
To Vendor		45,000

Block 3 (Wk 7–9): SQL + data. For analyst-flavored roles.

```
-- Revenue by region, last quarter, top to bottom
SELECT region,
       SUM(amount) AS revenue,
       COUNT(DISTINCT invoice_id) AS invoices
FROM   sales
WHERE  invoice_date ≥ '2026-04-01' AND invoice_date < '2026-07-01'
GROUP BY region
ORDER BY revenue DESC;

-- Running total (window function) – the interview differentiator
SELECT month,
       SUM(revenue) OVER (ORDER BY month) AS cumulative_revenue
FROM   monthly_sales;
```

Python for a quick reconciliation/summary — the reusable pattern:

```
import pandas as pd
gl = pd.read_csv("general_ledger.csv")
gl["amount"] = pd.to_numeric(gl["amount"], errors="coerce")
summary = (gl.groupby("cost_center")["amount"]
           .sum()
           .sort_values(ascending=False))
print(summary.head(10))
```

Block 4 (Wk 10–12): Power BI/DAX + packaging. Turn it into a dashboard and a story.

```
Total Revenue = SUM(Sales[Amount])
Revenue YoY % =
VAR Curr = [Total Revenue]
VAR Prior = CALCULATE([Total Revenue], SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR('Date'[Date]))
RETURN DIVIDE(Curr - Prior, Prior)
```


Worked example / mini-project

Project: "Kaveri Traders FY25-26 Finance Pack" — one dataset, carried through all four blocks. Invent a small trading firm: revenue ₹1.2 crore, COGS 65%, opex ₹18 lakh.

1. **Excel model:** Assumptions tab with growth 12%, COGS 65%, tax 25%. Build P&L → BS → Cash Flow. Add a 2-way data table flexing growth (8/12/16%) against COGS (60/65/70%) to see PAT swing. PAT at base ≈ ₹9.75 lakh.
2. **Tally + GST:** Book 12 months of sales/purchase vouchers. Compute net GST: output ₹21.6 lakh – ITC ₹14 lakh = **₹7.6 lakh cash payable**. Reconcile a deliberately-broken 2B (one vendor didn't file) and flag the ₹90,000 ITC you must hold.
3. **SQL/Python:** Load the 12-month sales CSV, GROUP BY region, find that "South" is 41% of revenue but declining QoQ.
4. **Power BI:** One page — revenue trend, region split, GST payable card, YoY% measure.

Ship it as a GitHub repo + a 1-page PDF summary. This is your portfolio.

How it's tested

Companies rarely take your word. Expect:

- **Timed Excel test (30–60 min):** "Here's a raw sales dump — build a pivot, compute margin by product, flag items below 20% margin." Or a lookup/cleanup task. Speed and no-hardcoding matter.
- **SQL screen (HackerRank / live share):** 2–3 queries escalating to a JOIN + window function.
- **"Close these books" case:** given a trial balance with errors, find and fix them; or record 5 vouchers in Tally and produce the TB.
- **GST/tax scenario:** "Sales ₹10L, purchases ₹6L, one supplier hasn't filed — what's your net payable and what do you do about the ITC?"
- **Model walkthrough:** they open your file and ask "why is this cell a formula and that one a constant?" and "what happens if growth halves?"

Interview questions: *Walk me through your DCF. What's the difference between GSTR-2A and 2B? When is ITC blocked (Sec 17(5))?* How do you reconcile a bank statement? Explain a LEFT vs INNER JOIN.

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

Mistake	What pros do
Hardcoding numbers inside formulas	All inputs on an assumptions tab; formulas reference them
Studying 6 skills shallowly, shipping nothing	One artifact per block — depth over breadth
Claiming ITC on everything	Claim only what's in GSTR-2B; check Sec 17(5) blocks
Circular refs / #REF! left in the model	Trace precedents, wrap risky bits in IFERROR, build clean
Memorizing DCF theory but never building one	Build the model 3×; the third time is muscle memory
No sensitivity/scenario view	Always add a data table — managers ask "what if"
Cramming, no spaced revision	Weekly review of prior blocks so Wk1 skills survive to Wk12

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Realistic time-to-proficiency at ~3 hrs/day: **the 90 days gets you interview-ready for entry/junior roles**, not senior. Extend to 6 months for depth.

Skill	Free	Paid / cert
Excel	ExcelJet, Leila Gharani (YouTube)	Microsoft MO-201
Accounting/Tally	Tally Education free courses	TallyPrime + GST certificate
GST/TDS	GST portal help, ClearTax guides	ICAI GST certificate course
SQL	Mode SQL Tutorial, SQLBolt, HackerRank	Google Data Analytics (Coursera)
Python	Kaggle "Pandas" micro-course	—
Power BI/DAX	Microsoft Learn (free)	Microsoft PL-300

Weekly cadence: 5 days new material, Saturday build the artifact, Sunday spaced review + mock question.

Quick-reference

Block 1 (Wk1-3): Excel + 3-statement model	→ Artifact: financial model
Block 2 (Wk4-6): Tally + GST/TDS + portal	→ Artifact: closed books + GST recon
Block 3 (Wk7-9): SQL + Python	→ Artifact: query pack + analysis
Block 4 (Wk10-12): Power BI/DAX + packaging	→ Artifact: dashboard + repo

Need	Formula / step
Lookup	<code>=XLOOKUP(key, col, return, "NA")</code>
Conditional sum	<code>=SUMIFS(sum, crit_rng, crit)</code>
YoY	<code>=IFERROR(this/prior-1,"n/a")</code>
Net GST	Output GST – ITC (in 2B only)
TDS 194J	10% on professional fees
SQL group	<code>SELECT dim, SUM(x) ... GROUP BY dim</code>
Window	<code>SUM(x) OVER (ORDER BY month)</code>
DAX YoY	<code>DIVIDE(Curr-Prior, Prior)</code>
Rule	Inputs on assumptions tab, never hardcode

The 6-Month Mastery Roadmap

What it is & where it's used

Chapters 1–7 gave you the raw skills — Excel, accounting mechanics, SQL, a bit of Python, GST/Tally, a modeling primer. This chapter is the **operating plan** that welds them into a hireable profile. A roadmap is not "study more." It is a sequenced, milestone-gated build where every month produces a **deliverable an interviewer can look at** — a working model, a reconciled book of accounts, a dashboard, a repo.

Where this matters: any candidate 0–3 years out. Hiring managers for FP&A, financial analyst, audit associate, tax executive, credit analyst, and finance-BA roles all screen the same way — they don't ask "did you learn Excel?", they ask "show me something you built." A structured 6-month portfolio is what turns "MBA Finance + CA Inter" (a credential thousands share) into "the person who built a 3-statement model of an actual listed company and can defend every driver."

The roadmap has three parallel tracks you deepen simultaneously:

Track	Core skill	Proof-of-work artifact
Modeling	3-statement + valuation in Excel	Fully-linked model of a real Indian listco
Data	SQL + Python + Power BI/DAX	A dashboard fed by a query you wrote
Domain	ONE chosen specialization	A case/deliverable specific to that domain

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

College teaches **subjects in isolation and tests recall**. Industry rewards **integrated output under a deadline**. The MBA gives you NPV formulas; it never makes you build a model where a change in a revenue-growth assumption ripples through the P&L, working capital, cash flow, and debt schedule and *still balances*. CA Inter drills you on standards and journal entries; it rarely makes you close a full month-end in Tally and produce a variance commentary a CFO would read.

The specific gap this roadmap closes:

- **Integration** — real work links accounting → modeling → data → decision. Nobody hands you a clean, pre-scoped problem.
- **Ownership of a deliverable** — you own something end-to-end, including the ugly reconciliation at the end.
- **Explaining your work** — "walk me through your model" is the single most common finance interview prompt, and it has no textbook answer.

Six months is enough to manufacture that experience *before* anyone pays you for it.

What "proficient" looks like

The bar an employer tests for at the end of this roadmap:

- Build a **3-statement model from a downloaded annual report in under 3 hours**, balance sheet tying out, no hardcodes over formulas, no circular-reference errors left unresolved.

- Write a **JOIN + GROUP BY SQL query** against an unfamiliar schema in 10 minutes to answer a business question.
- Take a raw transaction dump and produce a **Power BI dashboard with 3–4 DAX measures** (YoY, running total, % of total).
- **Close a set of books**: pass month-end journals, reconcile the bank and GST, produce a Trial Balance that agrees.
- **Defend every number** you present — "why 12% WACC?", "why did receivable days move?" — without freezing.

Proficiency = you can do the above **unaided, under time pressure, and explain it**.

Hands-on: how to actually do it

The month-by-month build

Month	Theme	Milestone (must-ship deliverable)	Checkpoint (pass/fail test)
1	Excel + accounting fluency	Rebuild a company's P&L + BS in Excel from its annual report	Balance sheet balances; zero hardcoded totals
2	3-statement model	Link IS → BS → CFS with a debt & working-capital schedule	Model flows when you change 1 driver; ties out
3	Valuation	Add DCF + comparables tab; arrive at a target price	You can justify WACC, terminal growth, exit multiple
4	Data — SQL	Load transaction data, answer 10 business questions in SQL	Correct JOIN/GROUP BY results, verified against Excel
5	Data — BI + Python	Power BI dashboard + a Python script that cleans the source	4 DAX measures correct; script reproducible
6	Domain track + polish	One domain deliverable + package the portfolio	Mock interview: walk through everything cleanly

Modeling track — the driver pattern

Never hardcode a forecast. Drive it. In Excel, a revenue build:

```
Revenue_next = Revenue_this * (1 + Growth_rate)
=B10*(1+$C$3)
```

Working-capital days that feed the cash flow:

```
Debtor Days    = Receivables / Revenue * 365      =B20/B10*365
Receivables    = Debtor Days assumption / 365 * Revenue
```

The circular-reference reality: interest depends on debt, debt depends on cash, cash depends on interest. Turn on **File → Options → Formulas → Enable iterative calculation** (max 100 iterations), and keep a **circularity switch** cell so you can break it when auditing:

```
Interest = IF($C$1=0, 0, Avg_Debt * Interest_rate)
```

Data track — SQL you will actually be asked

```
-- Top 5 customers by revenue in FY2024-25
SELECT c.customer_name,
       SUM(s.amount) AS total_revenue
FROM sales s
JOIN customers c ON c.customer_id = s.customer_id
WHERE s.invoice_date BETWEEN '2024-04-01' AND '2025-03-31'
GROUP BY c.customer_name
ORDER BY total_revenue DESC
LIMIT 5;

-- Month-on-month revenue with a window function
SELECT DATE_TRUNC('month', invoice_date) AS mth,
       SUM(amount) AS revenue,
       SUM(amount) - LAG(SUM(amount)) OVER (ORDER BY DATE_TRUNC('month', invoice_date)) AS mom
FROM sales
GROUP BY 1
ORDER BY 1;
```

Data track — Python to clean the raw dump

```
import pandas as pd

df = pd.read_csv("tally_export.csv")
df.columns = df.columns.str.strip().str.lower()
df["amount"] = (df["amount"].astype(str)
               .str.replace(",", "", regex=False)
               .astype(float))
df["invoice_date"] = pd.to_datetime(df["invoice_date"], dayfirst=True)

# Monthly revenue by state (GST use-case)
summary = (df.groupby([df["invoice_date"].dt.to_period("M"), "state"])["amount"]
           .sum().reset_index())
summary.to_csv("monthly_by_state.csv", index=False)
```

Data track — DAX measures for the dashboard

Total Revenue = SUM(Sales[Amount])

Revenue YoY % =

VAR Curr = [Total Revenue]

VAR Prior = CALCULATE([Total Revenue], SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR('Date'[Date]))

RETURN DIVIDE(Curr - Prior, Prior)

Running Total =

CALCULATE([Total Revenue],

FILTER(ALLSELECTED('Date'[Date]), 'Date'[Date] ≤ MAX('Date'[Date])))

Accounting track — a month-end close journal set

Date	Particulars	Dr (₹)	Cr (₹)
31-Mar	Depreciation A/c ... Dr	50,000	
	To Accumulated Depreciation		50,000
31-Mar	Salaries A/c ... Dr	2,00,000	
	To Salaries Payable (accrual)		2,00,000
31-Mar	Prepaid Insurance A/c ... Dr	12,000	
	To Insurance Expense		12,000

Choose ONE domain track (Month 6)

Domain	Deliverable	Signature skill
FP&A / Corporate finance	Rolling 12-month budget vs actuals + variance memo	Driver-based forecasting
Equity research	2-page initiation note with a rating	Valuation + thesis writing
Tax / GST	GSTR-2B vs purchase register reconciliation + ITC note	Portal + reconciliation
Audit	Sample testing workpaper + a control-deficiency memo	Sampling, documentation
Credit / lending	Credit appraisal note with ratio + DSCR analysis	Debt-serviceability judgement

Worked example / mini-project

The spine project: a full model + dashboard on an Indian listco (say, an FMCG mid-cap).

- Source data (Month 1).** Download the latest annual report. Type the last 3 years of P&L and BS into a **Historicals** tab. Verify: Assets = Liabilities + Equity for every year. Suppose Revenue ₹4,200 Cr, PAT ₹380 Cr.

2. **Build drivers (Month 2).** Assume revenue growth 11%, EBITDA margin 18%, debtor days 32, inventory days 45, tax 25%. Forecast 5 years. Link IS → BS → CFS. Add a debt schedule; opening ₹600 Cr, ₹100 Cr annual repayment. Confirm closing cash on the CFS = cash on the BS.
3. **Value it (Month 3).** WACC 12%, terminal growth 5%. Discount 5 years of FCFF plus a Gordon terminal value:

```
FCFF = EBIT*(1-tax) + Dep&Amort - Capex - Change in WC
Terminal Value = FCFF_year5 * (1+g) / (WACC - g)
Enterprise Value = SUM(PV of FCFF) + PV of Terminal Value
```

Cross-check with comparables (EV/EBITDA of 3 peers). Arrive at a target price, e.g. ₹1,450 vs market ₹1,300 → "Buy."

4. **Analyze the data (Month 4–5).** Export segment/region sales into SQLite, run the top-customer and MoM queries above. Clean with the Python snippet. Build a Power BI page: revenue trend, YoY %, margin bridge, region split — with the three DAX measures.
 5. **Domain wrap (Month 6).** If FP&A track: turn the forecast into a budget-vs-actual with a one-page variance commentary ("EBITDA ₹42 Cr below plan; ₹30 Cr is raw-material inflation, ₹12 Cr volume").
- Ship it as one folder + a GitHub repo. This single project touches every track.

How it's tested

- **The model walkthrough (universal).** "Take me through your model." They watch whether you know why each cell exists. Then a stress test: "revenue growth drops to 5% — what happens to the debt covenant?" You should be able to change it live.
- **Timed Excel test (60–90 min).** Build a mini 3-statement or a schedule from a given trial balance. Common at Big 4, corporate FP&A, KPO/GCC roles.
- **SQL screen (30–45 min).** HackerRank/DataCamp-style: JOINS, GROUP BY, window functions against a schema you've never seen.
- **The close case.** "Here's a trial balance and 6 adjustments — produce the finalized P&L and BS." Audit and controllership roles.
- **Case + guesstimate.** Equity research and credit: "value this business" or "would you lend to this company?" — judgement, not just arithmetic.
- **Behavioral.** "Tell me about a project you built end-to-end." Your portfolio is the answer.

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

Mistake	What pros do
Hardcoding numbers into formula cells	Colour code: blue = input, black = formula. Never type a number in a black cell.
Model doesn't balance, so they plug it	Build a balance check row (=Assets - L - E , should be 0). Find the error, never plug.
Ignoring the debt/interest circularity	Add an iterative-calc switch; understand <i>why</i> it's circular before disabling.
Learning tools in isolation	Force integration — the SQL query should feed the same company you modeled.
Chasing 5 domains shallowly	Pick one domain track. Depth beats breadth in interviews.
No commentary, just numbers	Always write the "so what" — 2 lines of insight per deliverable.
Studying without shipping	A milestone that isn't a file you can open didn't happen.

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Realistic time: 6 months at 10–12 focused hours/week gets you interview-ready; 20 hrs/week compresses it to ~3–4 months. The binding constraint is *shipping deliverables*, not watching lectures.

Need	Free	Paid / Cert
Modeling	Aswath Damodaran (NYU) YouTube + spreadsheets	WallStreetPrep, CFI FMVA
Excel	ExcelJet, Chandoo	Microsoft Excel Expert (MO-201)
SQL	Mode SQL Tutorial, SQLBolt, HackerRank	DataCamp
Python	Kaggle "Pandas" micro-course	—
Power BI / DAX	Microsoft Learn, SQLBI (Marco Russo)	PL-300 (Power BI Data Analyst)
Valuation / thesis	Damodaran, Tijori/Screeners.in for data	CFA L1 (India-recognized)
Tax/GST/Tally	GST portal + CBIC videos	TallyPrime certification

Sequencing rule: don't collect certificates first. Build the artifact, then take the cert that certifies what you already built — it reads as validation, not aspiration.

Quick-reference

The 6 milestones: (1) rebuilt financials → (2) linked 3-statement → (3) valuation + target price → (4) SQL answers → (5) BI dashboard + Python clean → (6) domain deliverable + portfolio.

Checkpoint questions (ask yourself monthly): - Does my balance sheet balance without a plug? - Can I change one driver and watch it flow? - Can I write a JOIN + GROUP BY unaided? - Can I defend every assumption out loud? - Is each month a *file I can send someone*?

Key formulas:

Growth-driven forecast	=PrevCell*(1+GrowthRate)
Debtor days	=Receivables/Revenue*365
FCFF	EBIT*(1-t)+D&A-Capex-ΔWC
Terminal value	FCFF*(1+g)/(WACC-g)
SQL essentials	JOIN ... ON GROUP BY LAG() OVER()
DAX YoY	DIVIDE(Curr-Prior, Prior) with SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR
Balance check	=TotalAssets-TotalLiab-Equity (must=0)

Colour convention: blue input · black formula · green = links to other sheets.

The one rule: every month ends with a shippable file, or the month didn't count.

Building a Portfolio That Gets Interviews

What it is & where it's used

A finance portfolio is a small, curated set of *finished, reviewable deliverables* that prove you can do the job before anyone hires you. For a fresher or a career-switcher with an MBA + CA Inter, it is the single fastest way to jump the resume screen: a recruiter reads 200 identical CVs ("proficient in Excel, strong analytical skills") and one that links to a working 3-statement model, a live Power BI dashboard, and a GitHub repo with SQL. Guess who gets the call.

Four deliverables carry almost every finance/accounts/tax role:

Deliverable	Roles it opens
3-statement model (Excel)	FP&A, corporate finance, equity research, investment banking, credit analyst
Power BI / dashboard	FP&A, business finance, MIS analyst, controllership, finance-BI
SQL / Python project	Finance analyst, data-heavy FP&A, fintech, revenue/GST analytics
Valuation write-up	Equity research, IB, PE/VC, corporate development

You don't need all four. Two done *well* beats four done shabbily. Pick the two that match your target role.

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

College taught you the *concepts* — CAPM, DCF, ratio analysis, the accounting equation. It graded you on knowing what NPV *is*. Employers pay you to *build the thing that produces the number* and defend it. The gap is almost entirely mechanical and habitual:

- MBA teaches "a DCF discounts free cash flows." It does **not** teach you to build a driver-based revenue schedule, tie a circular interest calculation with an iterative-calc toggle, or make the balance sheet actually balance.
- CA teaches you to *pass* journal entries. It does **not** teach you to pull 5 years of a company's financials from an annual report into a clean, formula-linked model that a manager can audit in 30 seconds.
- Nobody taught you version control, so your "final_v3_FINAL_actual.xlsx" habit screams fresher.

The portfolio closes this because it is *evidence of the mechanical skill*, not a claim about the conceptual one. It also proves the meta-skill employers most quietly value: you can take a messy real-world dataset and produce a decision-grade output, unaided.

What "proficient" looks like

The bar a hiring manager silently tests for:

- **3-statement model:** IS, BS, CFS fully linked; balance sheet balances to zero in every year and every scenario; assumptions on a separate, colour-coded input tab (blue = input, black = formula); a working scenario toggle; no hardcoded numbers inside formulas; circularity (interest on average debt) handled cleanly.

- **Dashboard:** loads from a data model (not one flat sheet), has slicers that actually filter, uses DAX measures (not calculated columns for everything), and answers a *business question* on the first screen ("are we hitting budget?") — not just "here are 9 charts."
- **SQL/Python:** you can write a multi-table `JOIN` with `GROUP BY`, a window function, and a CTE without googling syntax; Python code runs top-to-bottom in a clean environment and reads a real CSV.
- **Valuation:** a 2-3 page write-up with a thesis, a DCF *and* a comparables cross-check, a sensitivity table, and an explicit "what I'd need to be wrong about" section.

Hands-on: how to actually do it

1) The 3-statement model core mechanics

Keep inputs on a `Assumptions` tab and reference them. Never type a growth rate inside a P&L formula.

Revenue (Yr):	=PrevRevenue*(1+Assumptions!\$B\$4)	// growth driver
COGS:	=Revenue*Assumptions!\$B\$5	// % of sales
Depreciation:	=Opening_PPE*Assumptions!\$B\$8	// % of gross block
Interest expense:	=AVERAGE(Opening_Debt,Closing_Debt)*Assumptions!\$B\$10	// circular

Pull the right assumption automatically with a lookup instead of hardcoding scenario numbers:

```
=XLOOKUP($B$1, Scenarios[Case], Scenarios[RevGrowth])
```

where `$B$1` holds "Base" / "Bull" / "Bear".

The balance-sheet check (the formula an interviewer looks for first):

```
Check: =Total_Assets - (Total_Liabilities + Total_Equity) // must be 0 every year
```

Wrap the whole check row in conditional formatting: red if `ABS(check)>0.5`.

Circularity: interest depends on debt, debt depends on cash, cash depends on interest. Enable File > Options > Formulas > **Enable iterative calculation** (max 100, 0.001). Add a `Circuit Breaker` cell (a 1/0 switch) that zeroes interest so you can kill a `#REF!` spiral.

2) Power BI / DAX

Load data via Power Query (Get Data > CSV/Excel > Transform), then write measures — not calculated columns:

```
Total Revenue = SUM(Sales[Amount])
```

```
Revenue LY = CALCULATE([Total Revenue], SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR('Date'[Date]))
```

```
YoY % = DIVIDE([Total Revenue] - [Revenue LY], [Revenue LY])
```

```
Budget Variance % = DIVIDE([Total Revenue] - SUM(Budget[Amount]), SUM(Budget[Amount]))
```

Build a proper `Date` table so time-intelligence works:

```
Date = CALENDAR(DATE(2022,4,1), DATE(2025,3,31)) // Indian FY start
```

3) SQL project

A revenue-and-collections query a finance analyst actually writes:

```
WITH monthly AS (  
    SELECT  
        customer_id,  
        DATE_TRUNC('month', invoice_date) AS mth,  
        SUM(amount) AS revenue  
    FROM invoices  
    WHERE status = 'PAID'  
    GROUP BY customer_id, DATE_TRUNC('month', invoice_date)  
)  
SELECT  
    mth,  
    SUM(revenue) AS total_rev,  
    SUM(revenue) - LAG(SUM(revenue)) OVER (ORDER BY mth) AS mom_change  
FROM monthly  
GROUP BY mth  
ORDER BY mth;
```

4) Python

```
import pandas as pd

df = pd.read_csv("gst_sales_register.csv", parse_dates=["invoice_date"])
df["gst"] = df["taxable_value"] * 0.18

summary = (df.groupby(df["invoice_date"].dt.to_period("M"))
            .agg(taxable=("taxable_value", "sum"),
                 gst=("gst", "sum"),
                 invoices=("invoice_no", "count"))
            .round(0))

print(summary)
```

Worked example / mini-project

Project: "Kirana-to-Cloud Pvt Ltd — FY24 Finance Pack." Invent a small D2C company. Build one repo/model that produces three linked outputs.

Step 1 — Model. Assumptions: FY24 revenue ₹12,00,00,000, growing 20%; COGS 55% of sales; opex ₹2,40,00,000; debt ₹3,00,00,000 at 11%; tax 25%; capex ₹80,00,000.

Sample P&L (₹ lakh):

Line	FY24	FY25E
Revenue	1,200	1,440
COGS (55%)	660	792
Gross profit	540	648
Opex	240	264
EBITDA	300	384
Depreciation	40	48
EBIT	260	336
Interest (11%)	33	33
PBT	227	303
Tax (25%)	57	76
PAT	170	227

Step 2 — Dashboard. Export the sales register to CSV, load into Power BI, build a one-screen view: revenue vs budget card, YoY % KPI, monthly trend line, top-10 SKUs bar, a state slicer (ties to GST filing).

Step 3 — Valuation. Quick DCF: $FY25E\ FCFF \approx EBIT(1-t) + Dep - Capex - \Delta WC = 336 \times 0.75 + 48 - 80 - 20 \approx ₹200 \text{ lakh}$. Grow at 6% terminal, WACC 13%: terminal value = $200 \times 1.06 \div (0.13 - 0.06) \approx ₹3,028 \text{ lakh}$. Cross-

check with comps: peers trade at $12 \times \text{EBITDA} \rightarrow 384 \times 12 = ₹4,608$ lakh EV. Write 2 pages: thesis, both methods, a WACC sensitivity table, and your honest range (₹30–46 cr EV).

Reproduce it, screenshot the dashboard, commit the Excel + `.pbix` + a `README.md`.

How it's tested

Two layers: interview questions **and** a practical assessment.

Interview questions - "Walk me through your 3-statement model. If revenue grows 10%, what happens to the cash flow statement?" - "How does depreciation flow through all three statements?" (P&L –, add back in CFS, accumulated on BS) - "Your DCF gives ₹40 cr, comps give ₹46 cr. Why the gap, and which do you trust?" - "What DAX measure did you use for YoY, and why a measure not a column?"

Practical / take-home tests you'll actually get - **Timed Excel test (45–90 min)**: build a mini P&L from raw data, add a scenario toggle, VLOOKUP/XLOOKUP + INDEX-MATCH, a pivot. No internet. - **SQL screen (HackerRank/live)**: joins, `GROUP BY`, a window function, a CTE. - **Case study**: "Here's a trial balance / annual report — build the model and email it back in 24 hours." - **Dashboard task**: "Here's a CSV, build a dashboard that tells us if we're hitting target."

Your portfolio is the pre-loaded answer to all of these.

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

Mistake	What pros do
Hardcoding numbers inside formulas	All drivers on an input tab, referenced
Balance sheet doesn't balance; hidden plug	A visible <code>Check = Assets - (Liab+Equity)</code> row flagged red
No colour convention	Blue = input, black = formula, green = link to another tab
One giant flat sheet feeding Power BI	A Date table + star schema + measures
Dashboard with 12 charts, no message	One business question answered above the fold
"final_v4.xlsx" chaos	Git / GitHub with a real README
Copying a public model and calling it yours	Rebuild it yourself; you must defend every cell
Ignoring units	State "₹ lakh" once, top-left, and stay consistent

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Realistic time to a *credible two-deliverable portfolio*: **6–8 weeks** at ~1.5 hrs/day.

Week	Focus
1–2	Excel modeling mechanics; build the 3-statement model
3	DCF + valuation write-up
4–5	Power BI: Power Query, data model, DAX, one dashboard
6	SQL basics + one query project
7	Python + pandas for one data task
8	GitHub cleanup, READMEs, screenshots, polish

Resources - Free: Corporate Finance Institute free lessons; Microsoft Learn (Power BI); Mode SQL Tutorial / SQLBolt; Kaggle "Python" + "pandas" micro-courses; Aswath Damodaran's valuation lectures (YouTube, free).
- Paid (optional, India-relevant): CFI FMVA certificate (adds a line + structure); WallStreetPrep / Breaking Into Wall Street for modeling reps; Microsoft PL-300 (Power BI Data Analyst) if targeting BI-heavy finance roles. - Your CA Inter already gives you the accounting depth most competitors lack — lean on it; your gap is *tooling*, not concepts.

Showcasing: Create one GitHub repo, `finance-portfolio`. Structure: `/3-statement-model` (Excel + PDF export + README), `/valuation` (write-up PDF), `/powerbi` (`.pbix` + screenshot PNG in README — GitHub renders it), `/sql-python` (`.sql` , `.ipynb`). Write a top-level README with a one-line description and a screenshot per project. Put the repo link and the Power BI "Publish to web" link **on your resume and LinkedIn**. Pin the repo. That link is your interview magnet.

Quick-reference

```
Balance check:  =Assets-(Liabilities+Equity)           // target 0
Scenario pull:  =XLOOKUP($B$1,Scenarios[Case],Scenarios[RevGrowth])
Avg-debt interest: =AVERAGE(OpenDebt,CloseDebt)*rate    // needs iterative calc
Two-way lookup: =INDEX(rng,MATCH(row,rows,0),MATCH(col,cols,0))
```

DAX	Purpose
<code>SUM(Sales[Amount])</code>	base measure
<code>CALCULATE([Rev],SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR('Date'[Date]))</code>	last-year
<code>DIVIDE(a,b)</code>	safe division (no /0 error)

```
-- window function pattern
SUM(x) - LAG(SUM(x)) OVER (ORDER BY month)  -- MoM change
```

Convention	Rule
Colour	Blue input, black formula, green cross-tab link
Circularity	Enable iterative calc (100 / 0.001) + circuit breaker
Units	Declare "₹ lakh/cr" once, keep consistent
Version control	Git + README + screenshots; never <code>final_v3</code>
Showcase	Pinned GitHub repo + Power BI web link on resume & LinkedIn

One-line rule: ship two deliverables you can defend cell-by-cell, put the links where a recruiter will see them, and let the work skip you past the resume pile.

Skills-first resume & LinkedIn

What it is & where it's used

A **skills-first resume** flips the old script. Instead of leading with "Responsible for handling accounts payable," you lead with a demonstrable, measurable output built on a named tool: "*Automated a 400-line vendor reconciliation in Excel (XLOOKUP + Power Query), cutting month-end close from 3 days to 4 hours.*" The verb is an action, the tool is explicit, and the result is a number.

This matters for **every** finance/accounts/tax role you'll target in India or abroad:

Role	What recruiters scan for
Accounts Executive / R2R	Tally, GST returns, BRS, journal entries, Excel
FP&A / Financial Analyst	Excel modeling, variance analysis, Power BI, SQL
Audit / Assurance	SA/Ind AS references, sampling, working papers, CaseWare
Tax (Direct/Indirect)	GST portal, TDS, Form 26AS, ITR filing, reconciliations
Data-facing finance	SQL, Python (pandas), DAX, dashboarding

The resume and LinkedIn profile are two front-ends to the **same skills database**. An ATS (Applicant Tracking System) and a human recruiter both do keyword matching first, judgement second. Your job is to pass the keyword pass, then survive the human read.

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

An MBA teaches you *frameworks* (Porter, WACC theory, capital structure). CA Inter teaches you *standards* (Ind AS 115, SA 700, GST Sec 16). Neither produces the artifact an employer actually pays for: **a working file that saves someone time or catches an error.**

The gap is specific:

- College graded you on **answers**; the job grades you on **repeatable process** (a model someone else can open and trust).
- Your CV likely lists **courses and marks**; a recruiter can't hire a mark — they hire a person who can build a cost sheet in TallyPrime and file a GSTR-3B without supervision.
- ATS software rejects ~60-70% of resumes before a human sees them, almost always for **missing keywords** — the exact tool names and standard references you assumed were "obvious."

Closing this gap costs nothing but rewriting. You already *did* the Excel model in a group project — you just described it as "prepared financial analysis" instead of "built a 3-statement model with a circular-reference interest toggle."

What "proficient" looks like

A job-ready skills-first profile clears this bar **unaided**:

1. Every bullet has the shape **[Action verb] + [tool/skill] + [quantified result]**. No result-free bullets.

2. The **top third** of page one (the "above the fold" zone recruiters read in 6 seconds) contains a Skills/Tools summary and 2-3 headline achievements — not your address and objective statement.
3. The exact tool nouns appear verbatim: TallyPrime , GSTR-1 , Excel (XLOOKUP, SUMIFS, Power Query) , SQL , Power BI (DAX) , Ind AS , TDS , 26AS , BRS .
4. LinkedIn headline is a **positioning statement**, not a job title: "Accounts & GST | Tally + Advanced Excel | CA Inter | Automating month-end close".
5. One line is verifiable: a GitHub link, a public dashboard, a Google Sheet, or a specific number a reference could confirm.

Hands-on: how to actually do it

Rewrite a weak bullet — the mechanics

Take a bullet and pass it through three filters: **Tool named? Number attached? Verb strong?**

Weak (college voice)	Strong (skills-first)
Handled monthly reconciliation	Reconciled 12 bank accounts monthly in Excel using SUMIFS + conditional flags, surfacing ₹2.1L of duplicate vendor payments
Assisted in GST filing	Filed GSTR-1 and GSTR-3B for a 40-invoice/month firm; matched ITC against GSTR-2B, reducing mismatches to zero
Made financial models	Built a 3-statement model in Excel with a debt-schedule circularity toggle; used it to test 3 capex scenarios
Worked on data analysis	Wrote SQL to pull 18 months of sales and built a Power BI dashboard tracking 6 KPIs, refreshed weekly

Prove the Excel claim (so it's not a bluff)

The bullet says XLOOKUP + SUMIFS. Be ready to show the actual formulas:

```
=XLOOKUP(A2, Vendors[VendorID], Vendors[GSTIN], "NOT FOUND")
=SUMIFS(Ledger[Amount], Ledger[Party], A2, Ledger[Month], "Mar-26")
=IFERROR(XLOOKUP(...), "Check master")      'never leave #N/A in a client file
```

Prove the SQL claim

```
SELECT vendor_id,
       COUNT(*)      AS invoices,
       SUM(taxable_val) AS taxable,
       SUM(igst+cgst+sgst) AS total_tax
FROM   purchases
WHERE  invoice_date BETWEEN '2025-04-01' AND '2026-03-31'
GROUP BY vendor_id
HAVING SUM(taxable_val) > 500000
ORDER BY total_tax DESC;
```

Prove the Python claim

```
import pandas as pd
gstr2b = pd.read_excel("GSTR2B.xlsx")
books = pd.read_excel("PurchaseRegister.xlsx")
recon = books.merge(gstr2b, on="invoice_no", how="outer",
                    indicator=True, suffixes=("_books", "_2b"))
mismatch = recon[recon["_merge"] != "both"] # ITC not matching
mismatch.to_excel("ITC_mismatch.xlsx", index=False)
```

Prove the DAX claim (Power BI)

```
Total Tax = SUM(Purchases[TotalTax])
ITC Matched % =
DIVIDE(
    CALCULATE([Total Tax], Purchases[MatchStatus] = "Matched"),
    [Total Tax], 0)
```

The ATS keyword pass

Copy the job description into a doc. Highlight every noun that is a tool, standard, or task (Tally , Ind AS 116 , variance analysis , TDS , SQL). If your resume doesn't contain that exact string, and you can honestly claim it, add it. ATS does literal matching — "MS Excel" and "Excel" are fine, but "spreadsheets" won't match a search for "Excel."

Worked example / mini-project

Goal: turn one real thing you did into a portfolio bullet + LinkedIn line + interview story.

You built a GST input-tax-credit reconciliation for a friend's trading firm. Realistic numbers:

Metric	Value
Purchase invoices / month	320
ITC as per books	₹4,80,000
ITC as per GSTR-2B	₹4,52,000
Mismatch found	₹28,000 (11 invoices)
Time before automation	~6 hours manual
Time after (Power Query)	25 minutes

The journal entry you'd pass for the ₹28,000 blocked/deferred ITC:

Account	Dr (₹)	Cr (₹)
ITC Receivable – Under Reconciliation A/c	28,000	
Input CGST A/c		14,000
Input SGST A/c		14,000

Resume bullet:

Built a Power Query + Python ITC reconciliation matching a 320-invoice/month purchase register against GSTR-2B; identified ₹28,000 of unmatched credit and cut the monthly recon from 6 hours to 25 minutes.

LinkedIn "Featured" post (2 lines):

Automated a GST ITC reconciliation this week — Power Query pulls the register, Python matches it to GSTR-2B, mismatches export in one click. 6 hours → 25 minutes. Steps + sample file in comments. #GST #Excel #Finance

Interview story (STAR): *Situation:* manual recon, credit leaking. *Task:* find the gap fast. *Action:* built the merge (showed the `indicator=True` pandas code above). *Result:* ₹28k recovered, 93% time saved, now runs monthly.

That single project feeds three assets. Do this for 3-4 projects and your profile is done.

How it's tested

Employers rarely take the resume at face value. Expect:

- **Timed Excel test (30-45 min):** given a raw dataset, "build a summary with SUMIFS/XLOOKUP, add a pivot, flag duplicates, and 3 charts." Speed and keyboard shortcuts are watched.
- **"Close these books" case:** a trial balance with 8-10 pending adjustments (depreciation, prepaid, accruals, a wrong GST posting). You pass entries and produce a P&L + Balance Sheet.
- **SQL screen:** 2-3 queries — a `GROUP BY` aggregate, a `JOIN`, and a `HAVING` filter. Very common for FP&A/analyst roles.
- **GST/tax practical:** "Here are 20 invoices — compute output tax, ITC, and net GST payable; which ITC is blocked under Sec 17(5)?"
- **Resume defense questions:** "Walk me through the XLOOKUP you used", "Why XLOOKUP over VLOOKUP?" (answer: works left-to-right agnostic, returns arrays, native `if_not_found`). If you can't defend a bullet, **delete it**.

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

Mistake	Fix
Objective statement ("seeking a challenging role...")	Delete it. Replace with a 2-line skills summary.
Result-free bullets ("handled," "assisted," "worked on")	Every bullet gets a number or a named output.
Listing "MS Office" as a skill	Name the <i>functions</i> : XLOOKUP, SUMIFS, Power Query, pivot tables.
Skills you can't demo	If you can't pass a 10-min test on it, don't list it.
Photo-heavy, multi-column resume that ATS can't parse	Single column, standard headings, <code>.docx</code> or text-based PDF.
Same resume for every job	Re-order skills to mirror each job description's keywords.
LinkedIn headline = "Student at XYZ"	Make it a positioning line with tools + target role.
Empty LinkedIn "Featured" and "Projects"	Pin 2-3 project artifacts; recruiters click these.

Pros also keep a **master resume** (everything) and cut a **tailored 1-pager** per application in 10 minutes.

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Time to a job-ready profile: 2-3 weekends (the skills you're describing you should already have; this is packaging).

Week	Do this
1	List 4 real projects. Write each as Action+Tool+Number. Pass every bullet through the 3 filters.
1	Rebuild resume as single-column <code>.docx</code> ; add a "Tools" line. Run it through Jobscan/free ATS checker.
2	Rewrite LinkedIn: headline, About (3 short paras), Skills section (pin top 3), one Featured project post.
2	Ask 2 people for a specific-skill recommendation; endorse to seed reciprocity.

Resources (mostly free): - Harvard/most-college resume guides (PDF) — for the single-column skeleton. - Jobscan / Resume Worded — free ATS keyword match score. - LinkedIn's own "Skills" and SSI (Social Selling Index) page. - Excel: ExcelJet (formula reference), Chandoo (India-context). - SQL: SQLBolt, Mode SQL Tutorial (free, browser-based). - Certifications that read well on a finance CV: **Microsoft Excel Expert (MO-201)**, **Google Data Analytics (Coursera)**, **Microsoft PL-300 (Power BI)**, plus your **CA Inter** progress stated plainly.

Quick-reference

Bullet formula: [Strong verb] + [named tool] + [quantified result]

Strong verbs: Built, Automated, Reconciled, Modeled, Reduced, Filed, Analyzed, Forecasted, Audited, Streamlined.

Must-name tool keywords (India finance):

TallyPrime · Excel (XLOOKUP, SUMIFS, Power Query, pivots) · SQL ·
Power BI (DAX) · Python (pandas) · GSTR-1 · GSTR-3B · GSTR-2B ·
TDS · Form 26AS · BRS · Ind AS · SA 700 · variance analysis

Resume structure (top → bottom): Name + contact → 2-line summary → Tools/Skills line →
Achievements/Projects → Experience → Education (CA Inter, MBA) → Certifications.

LinkedIn headline template: [Function] | [Tool 1] + [Tool 2] | [Credential] | [1-line value] e.g.
Accounts & Tax | TallyPrime + Advanced Excel | CA Inter | Cutting month-end close times

6-second test: cover everything below the top third of page one — can a stranger tell what you do and prove it? If not, fix the top third first.

The interview-prep system

What it is & where it's used

An interview-prep *system* is a repeatable, calendar-driven routine that turns "I hope they don't ask something hard" into "I have rehearsed this exact answer out loud." It has three tracks that every finance hiring loop tests, in some mix:

1. **Technical** — accounting, valuation, tax, FM concepts, GST/TDS mechanics, IFRS/Ind AS.
2. **Practical / assessment test** — a timed Excel model, a SQL screen, a "close these books" case, a live TallyPrime task, a GST return walk-through.
3. **Behavioral** — "walk me through a time you missed a deadline," fit, communication.

Where it's used: **every** role you're targeting — Big 4 audit/tax, FP&A/finance-analyst seats, controllership, treasury, equity research, KPO/GCC finance ops (Genpact, WNS, Deloitte USI), startup finance. The mix changes: audit leans technical + case; FP&A leans Excel test + behavioral; research leans modelling case + market view; KPO leans a timed assessment + versant English test.

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

MBA and CA theory teaches you *what* a DCF is. The interview tests whether you can **build one in Excel in 25 minutes**, defend the WACC, and explain why $FCFF \neq PAT$. College grades a written exam; employers grade a **live, timed, unaided performance** under a stranger's questions. Nobody in class made you say "I don't know, but here's how I'd find out" without panicking.

The specific gaps this chapter closes:

- **Recall** → **retrieval under pressure**. You know depreciation; can you post the entry when the interviewer stares at you?
- **Answers** → **structured answers**. Behavioral rounds reward STAR structure, not rambling.
- **One-size prep** → **role-specific prep**. Prepping the same 20 questions for audit and FP&A wastes both loops.
- **Cramming** → **cadence**. Mock tests spaced over weeks beat a panicked all-nighter.

What "proficient" looks like

A job-ready candidate can, **unaided**:

Track	The bar an interviewer is testing for
Technical	Answer a concept in 60–90 sec: definition → why → one number/example. Handle a 2-level follow-up ("and if rates rise?").
Practical	Finish a timed Excel/SQL/Tally task correctly with keyboard, no mouse-hunting, no Googling formulas.
Behavioral	Deliver a STAR story in ~2 min with a real metric ("cut the close from 8 to 5 days").
Meta	Say "I don't know" cleanly, then reason toward an answer.

Concretely: build a 3-statement model skeleton in <30 min; write a `GROUP BY` join without help; compute GST liability with ITC set-off; explain deferred tax with an entry.

Hands-on: how to actually do it

1. Build a question bank, then rehearse out loud

Maintain a tracker (Excel/Notion). Columns: `Question` | `Track` | `Role` | `My 90-sec answer` | `Confidence 1-5` | `Last practiced`. Filter by confidence to know what to drill.

Quick Excel to surface weak spots:

```
=FILTER(A2:F200, (E2:E200 ≤ 3)*(C2:C200="FP&A"))
```

Sort by last-practiced so nothing goes stale:

```
=SORTBY(A2:F200, F2:F200, 1)
```

2. Technical drills — say the answer in a formula/entry, not prose

Rehearse *the artifact*, not a paragraph. Examples you should be able to produce instantly:

Deferred tax on faster book vs tax depreciation (India, timing difference):

Particulars	Dr (₹)	Cr (₹)
Deferred Tax Expense (P&L)	25,000	
To Deferred Tax Liability		25,000

FCFF from PAT — recite the bridge:

```
FCFF = PAT + Interest*(1-t) + Depreciation - Capex - ΔWorking Capital
```

Valuation multiple sanity check in Excel:

```
=EV / EBITDA // e.g. =4500/600 → 7.5x, then compare to peer median
```

3. Practical-test drills — timed, keyboard-only

Excel screen (FP&A/analyst). Practice these until they're muscle memory:

```
=XLOOKUP(A2, Master[Code], Master[Name], "Not found")
=SUMIFS(Amount, Region, "South", Month, "≥"&DATE(2026,4,1))
=IFERROR(Rev/Prev-1, "n/a") // MoM growth, guarded
=EOMONTH(TODAY(),-1) // last month-end for aging
```

SQL screen (KPO/GCC/analytics). Rehearse the classic "top vendors by spend":


```
SELECT v.vendor_name,
       SUM(i.amount)      AS total_spend,
       COUNT(*)           AS invoice_count
FROM   invoices i
JOIN   vendors v ON v.vendor_id = i.vendor_id
WHERE  i.invoice_date ≥ '2026-04-01'
GROUP BY v.vendor_name
HAVING SUM(i.amount) > 100000
ORDER BY total_spend DESC
LIMIT 10;
```

Python (data/analyst roles). A 5-line profit-margin cut they can ask you to write:

```
import pandas as pd
df = pd.read_csv("sales.csv")
df["margin"] = (df["revenue"] - df["cogs"]) / df["revenue"]
print(df.groupby("region")["margin"].mean().sort_values())
```

DAX (Power BI dashboards):

```
Total Revenue = SUM(Sales[Revenue])
YoY % = DIVIDE([Total Revenue] - CALCULATE([Total Revenue], SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR('Date'[Date])),
```

TallyPrime / GST-portal (accounts/tax roles). Be able to narrate the click-path: - Tally sales entry: Gateway of Tally → Vouchers → F8 (Sales) → party → item → GST auto-computes → Ctrl+A to save . - GSTR-3B: gst.gov.in → login → Returns Dashboard → select period → GSTR-3B → Prepare Online → fill 3.1 outward + 4 ITC → Save → Proceed to Pay → File with DSC/EVC .

4. Behavioral — STAR, timed to 2 minutes

Write 6–8 stories once, in this frame:

| S | Situation (1 line, context) | | T | Task (what you owned) | | A | Action (2–3 specific things *you* did) | | R | Result (a **number**) |

Example: "Month-end close ran 8 days (S). I owned the payables reconciliation (T). I built a SUMIFS-based auto-match sheet and a daily cut-off checklist (A). Close dropped to 5 days, and unmatched entries fell 70% (R)."

Worked example / mini-project: a 2-week prep sprint for one FP&A role

Target: **Finance Analyst, FMCG GCC, Bengaluru.** JD says: Excel modelling, variance analysis, SQL basics, stakeholder communication.

Step 1 — decode the JD into a prep map:

JD phrase	Track	Drill
"budget vs actual variance"	Technical + Excel	Build a variance sheet with SUMIFS + % delta
"SQL to pull data"	Practical	10 GROUP BY/JOIN queries
"partner with business"	Behavioral	2 stakeholder STAR stories

Step 2 — build the reproducible variance model. Data: budget ₹1.20 cr, actual ₹1.38 cr for a South region quarter.

Variance	=Actual - Budget	// =13800000-12000000 → 1,800,000
Variance %	=(Actual-Budget)/Budget	// → 15.0%
Flag	=IF(ABS(Variance%)>0.10,"Investigate","OK")	

Then a one-line commentary you rehearse aloud: *"South is 15% over budget, ₹18 lakh, driven by trade-promo overspend; volume was on plan, so it's a price/mix issue — I'd pull the promo calendar next."*

Step 3 — mock the SQL using the vendor query above on sample data.

Step 4 — run a full 45-min mock: 15 min technical Q&A, 20 min Excel+SQL, 10 min behavioral. Score yourself, log gaps in the tracker, re-drill the ≤3 confidence items.

How it's tested

Interview questions you'll actually get: - Technical: "Walk me through the three statements and how they link." / "What's deferred tax?" / "FCFF vs FCFE?" / "How does ITC set-off work under GST?" - Behavioral: "Tell me about a deadline you missed." / "A time you disagreed with a manager."

Practical/assessment tests companies actually give:

Role	The real test
FP&A / analyst	Timed 30–45 min Excel: build variance/forecast from raw data, no internet
KPO / GCC ops	Online assessment: Excel + a SQL screen + Versant/English test
Equity research	"Model this company" case, 60–90 min, plus a stock pitch
Audit (Big 4)	Case study: risks in a scenario; sometimes a sampling/ratio exercise
Accounts / tax	"Post these entries" or a live Tally task; GST return walk-through

Expect a **take-home** for some (build a model overnight) and a **live-share** for others (screen-share while you type). Practice both — narrating while typing is a separate skill.

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

Mistake	Pro move
Only reading notes, never speaking answers	Rehearse out loud , timed, ideally recorded
Prepping generic questions for every role	Decode each JD into a prep map first
Mouse-hunting in Excel tests	Learn keyboard: Alt+= autosum, F4 absolute ref, Ctrl+Shift+↓ select
Rambling behavioral answers	STAR, 2 min max, end on a metric
Cramming the night before	Space mocks over 2–4 weeks (cadence below)
Bluffing when stuck	"I don't know — here's how I'd reason it out"
Ignoring the "any questions for us?" close	Prepare 3 sharp questions about the team/metrics

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Time to interview-ready: 3–4 weeks of ~1 hr/day if your fundamentals are solid; 6–8 weeks if you're also relearning Excel/SQL.

Mock-test cadence (the backbone):

Week	Cadence
1	Build question bank; 2 self-mocks (technical only)
2	3 mocks: add timed Excel/SQL; log gaps daily
3	3 mocks with a peer/mentor as interviewer; full loop
4	2 dress-rehearsal mocks; taper, review tracker only

Rule: **one full timed mock every 2–3 days**, never fewer than two before a real interview. Re-drill only ≤ 3 -confidence items — don't re-practice what you've mastered.

Resources (free unless noted): - Technical: *Breaking Into Wall Street / Wall Street Prep* (paid) for modelling; *Corporate Finance Institute* free articles; ICAI study material for Ind AS/tax. - Excel/SQL/Python: Microsoft Excel functions docs, Mode SQL tutorial (free), Kaggle Python micro-courses (free). - Behavioral: Google "STAR method finance"; write your 8 stories in a doc. - Practice sets: Glassdoor + AmbitionBox (India) for company-specific asked questions. - Certifications that double as prep: **NISM** (research analyst), **CFA L1** (technical depth), **Microsoft Excel (MO-201)**.

Quick-reference

The 3 tracks: Technical (concept in 90 sec) · Practical (timed, keyboard-only) · Behavioral (STAR, 2 min, end on a number).

Excel test essentials: **XLOOKUP**, **SUMIFS**, **IFERROR**, **EOMONTH**; keys **Alt+=**, **F4**, **Ctrl+Shift+Arrow**, **Ctrl+A** (save in Tally).

SQL screen essentials: JOIN ... ON , GROUP BY , HAVING , ORDER BY ... DESC , LIMIT .

FCFF bridge: $PAT + Int \times (1 - t) + Dep - Capex - \Delta WC$.

GST filing path: gst.gov.in → Returns Dashboard → GSTR-3B → fill 3.1 & 4 → Save → Pay → File .

Cadence: 1 full timed mock every 2–3 days; ≥ 2 before any real interview; re-drill only confidence ≤ 3 .

When stuck: "I don't know — here's how I'd find out," then reason aloud.

Networking & the finance job search

What it is & where it's used

The "finance job search" is a distribution problem, not a knowledge problem. You already have the domain skills (from earlier chapters). This chapter is about *how a role travels from a hiring manager's head to your inbox* — and how to intercept it. It applies to every finance/accounts/tax role you'll target in India and abroad: FP&A analyst, accounts executive, GST/direct-tax associate, credit analyst, treasury, audit, equity research, investment banking, and controllership.

The uncomfortable data point: in India, roughly **30–40% of white-collar hires happen through referrals**, and at analyst/associate finance levels it's higher because managers trust "someone vouched for them" over a resume they can't verify. Job portals (Naukri, LinkedIn, Indeed) and campus placement fill most of the rest; cold outreach and recruiters fill the gaps. Globally the shape is identical — LinkedIn and employee referral programs dominate. So the skill being taught here is **manufacturing referrals and warm intros on demand**, plus running applications like a pipeline instead of a lottery.

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

MBA placement cells and CA articleship create a dangerous illusion: that jobs *arrive*. You register, a company visits, you interview, you get placed. That machine works exactly once. The moment you're an off-campus, lateral, or Direct-Entry candidate, nobody delivers roles to you — and most graduates freeze because they were never taught the mechanics of self-sourced hiring.

The specific gaps:

- **Nobody taught you the hidden market.** A large share of roles are filled before they're publicly posted, or posted only for compliance after an internal referral already exists.
- **You were taught to "apply," not to route.** Blasting 200 applications on Naukri yields a ~2% callback because you're a stranger in an ATS keyword pile.
- **You think networking = asking for a job.** It doesn't. It's asking for *information and a 15-minute conversation*, which incidentally produces referrals.
- **No one showed you a recruiter is a channel, not a friend.** They're paid by the employer to fill a specific req — you must speak in their currency (fit, salary, notice period).

What "proficient" looks like

A job-ready candidate can, unaided:

- Build a **target list of 30–50 companies** and identify the actual hiring manager (not just HR) for each.
- Write a cold message that gets a **20%+ reply rate** because it's specific, short, and asks for one small thing.
- Convert a stranger into a **referral inside 2–3 touches** without ever bluntly begging for a job.
- Run an **application tracker** (a pipeline) with follow-up dates, and treat it like a sales funnel.
- Tailor a resume to a specific JD so it **clears the ATS** and reads as an obvious fit.
- Handle a recruiter call crisply: current CTC, expected CTC, notice period, reason for change, in under 90 seconds.

The bar is behavioural: can you generate 3 warm conversations this week from a cold start? A proficient job-seeker can.

Hands-on: how to actually do it

1. Build the target-company tracker (your CRM)

Use a Google Sheet. These formulas make it a live pipeline.

Days since you applied / last touched, and an auto "FOLLOW UP" flag:

```
=TODAY()-B2 // days since last contact (B2 = date)
=IF(AND(C2="Applied", (TODAY()-B2)>7), "FOLLOW UP", "") // C2 = stage
```

Pull the hiring manager's name into your message template automatically:

```
=SUBSTITUTE("Hi {name}, I saw the {role} opening at {co}", "{name}", D2)
```

In Excel, count how your funnel is converting:

```
=COUNTIF(C:C, "Applied") // top of funnel
=COUNTIF(C:C, "Interview")/COUNTIF(C:C, "Applied") // application→interview rate
```

Columns to keep: Company | HM Name | Role | Source | Date | Stage | Referral? | Next action | Notes .

2. Find the actual hiring manager

LinkedIn search string (paste into the search bar):

```
"FP&A" AND ("hiring" OR "manager") AND "Bangalore"
```

Or use LinkedIn filters: **People** → **Current company** = [Target] → **Title contains "Finance Manager" / "Controller" / "Team Lead – Accounts"**. Guess their email with the company's pattern (`firstname.lastname@company.com` is the most common in India), then verify format against any public email from the domain.

3. The cold message that actually works

Structure = **specific hook** → **credibility in one line** → **one small ask**. Keep it under 90 words.

Subject: FP&A Analyst role – quick question

Hi Priya,

I saw Zomato is hiring an FP&A Analyst. I'm an MBA (Finance) + CA-Inter, and I recently built a 3-statement model + variance dashboard in Excel/Power BI for a D2C P&L (happy to share).

Before I apply, could I ask you one thing – is this role more about monthly-close reporting or forward budgeting? Want to make sure my application speaks to what your team actually needs.

Thanks either way,

Sai | [linkedin.com/in/...](#)

Why it works: you did homework, you proved output, and the ask ("one question") is trivially easy to answer — which starts a conversation that ends in a referral.

4. The referral ask (touch 2 or 3, never touch 1)

Never open with "refer me." Earn it first, then:

"This was really helpful, thank you. I'm going to apply — would you be comfortable referring me internally? Totally fine if not. If it helps, here's a 3-line summary you can paste and my resume attached."

Make it **zero-effort** for them: give the paste-ready blurb and the file. That single move roughly doubles referral conversion.

5. Beat the ATS on the application itself

ATS (Naukri RMS, Workday, Greenhouse) rank on keyword match. Mirror the JD's exact nouns. Quick keyword-gap check in Python:

```
jd = open("jd.txt").read().lower().split()
cv = open("resume.txt").read().lower().split()
missing = set(jd) - set(cv)
for w in ["reconciliation", "variance", "gst", "tds", "forecasting", "sql", "excel"]:
    print(w, "MISSING" if w in missing else "ok")
```

Add the missing (true) skills verbatim to your resume. Use a single-column, no-graphics `.docx` — ATS parsers choke on tables and text boxes.

Worked example / mini-project

Goal: land interviews for an FP&A / Accounts Analyst role in Bengaluru in 3 weeks, from a cold start.

Week 1 — Build & source. List 40 companies (mix of MNC GCCs, startups, mid-cap manufacturers). For each, find one hiring manager on LinkedIn. Tracker snapshot:

Company	HM	Role	Source	Stage	Referral?
Zomato	Priya S.	FP&A Analyst	LinkedIn	Messaged	Pending
Tata Elxsi	Rajesh N.	Accounts Exec	Naukri	Applied	No
Razorpay	Meera K.	Finance Analyst	Referral	Interview	Yes

Week 2 — Outreach. Send 8 cold messages/day (5 days = 40). Realistic funnel:

Stage	Count	Rate
Messages sent	40	—
Replies	9	22%
Calls/chats	4	—
Referrals secured	3	—
Direct applications	40	—

Week 3 — Convert. 3 referrals + 40 applications. A referred application at analyst level converts to a first-round interview at roughly **40–50%** vs **~2–3%** cold. Expected interviews: $(3 \times 0.45) + (40 \times 0.025) \approx 1.35 + 1.0 = \sim 2.4$. So **~2–3 interviews** in three weeks — and note that **the 3 referrals produced as many interviews as 40 blind applications**. That single insight is the entire chapter.

CTC math for the negotiation (know this cold before any recruiter call):

Current CTC ₹6,00,000 → target +30% = ₹7,80,000

In-hand $\approx$ CTC - PF(both sides) - prof.tax - income tax

Anchor high but justified; state expected CTC as a range: ₹7.5–8.5L

How it's tested

The "test" here is the process itself, but employers do screen on adjacent skills. Expect:

Recruiter phone screen (5–10 min), verbatim questions: - "Walk me through your resume in 2 minutes." (Have a rehearsed 90-sec pitch.) - "Current CTC, expected CTC, notice period?" - "Why are you looking to change / why this role?" - "Are you comfortable with [location / shift / CTC band]?"

Behavioural / fit round: - "Tell me about a time you handled a tight deadline." (Use STAR: Situation-Task-Action-Result.) - "Why our company specifically?" — this is where your networking research pays: name the team, the product, something real.

The practical screen (role-dependent, covered in earlier chapters): a timed Excel test, a SQL query screen, or a "close these books / reconcile this ledger" case. Networking gets you *to* the test; it doesn't replace it.

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

Mistake	What pros do
Blasting 200 identical applications	40 targeted, each with a tailored resume + a referral attempt
Opening a cold DM with "please refer me"	Ask a smart question first; earn the referral over 2–3 touches
Long, generic messages ("I am a passionate finance professional...")	Under 90 words, specific hook, one small ask
Treating recruiters as career counsellors	Speak their currency: fit, CTC, notice period, availability
No follow-up	Follow up once after 5–7 days; ~30% of replies come from the nudge
Networking only when unemployed	Keep 5 warm contacts alive year-round — the best time to network is before you need it
Lying about CTC/notice	Recruiters verify via payslips/relieving letters; inflating gets offers revoked
Ignoring the ATS	Mirror JD keywords, single-column .docx, no tables/graphics

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Time to proficiency: 2–4 weeks of active practice (this is a *doing* skill, not a studying skill).

Week	Focus
1	Build tracker + target list; optimise LinkedIn profile (banner, headline with keywords, "Open to Work")
2	Send 40 cold messages; do 3 informational chats
3	Convert to referrals + applications; run the funnel
4	Interview prep, follow-ups, negotiation rehearsal

Resources: - *LinkedIn* — free; your primary sourcing + outreach tool. Complete the profile to "All-Star." - *Naukri* / *Indeed* / *iimjobs* (for finance/consulting) / *Instahyre* — India job boards; iimjobs and Instahyre skew higher for MBA-finance roles. - Company career pages + **GCC (Global Capability Centre) portals** — Bengaluru/Hyderabad/Pune are packed with MNC finance shared-service roles. - *Naukri* "Recruiter Connection" and LinkedIn Recruiter InMails — respond fast; recruiters work FIFO. - Books: *Never Eat Alone* (Ferrazzi) for networking mindset; *Cracking the finance interview* guides for role-specific prep. - Certification signal: your **CA-Inter + MBA** already clears most screens — no extra networking cert needed. Spend the money on a Power BI / SQL cert instead (covered earlier), which makes your cold messages credible.

Quick-reference

Item	Value / formula
Referral share of hires (India)	~30–40%
Referred vs cold interview conversion	~45% vs ~2–3%
Cold message length	< 90 words, one ask
Reply rate to aim for	20%+
Follow-up timing	once, after 5–7 days
Outreach cadence	8 messages/day
Days-since-touch flag	<code>=IF((TODAY()-B2)>7,"FOLLOW UP","")</code>
Funnel conversion	<code>=COUNTIF(C:C,"Interview")/COUNTIF(C:C,"Applied")</code>
Email guess pattern (India)	<code>firstname.lastname@company.com</code>
Recruiter screen essentials	Current CTC · Expected CTC · Notice period · Reason for change
Referral ask rule	Never touch #1; give paste-ready blurb + resume
Resume format for ATS	Single-column .docx, JD keywords mirrored, no tables
Negotiation anchor	+25–35% on current CTC, stated as a range
STAR	Situation → Task → Action → Result

AI-Era Finance Careers

What it is & where it's used

"AI in finance" is not a job title — it is a layer that now sits under almost every finance task you already do. The reader who masters this chapter does not become a "prompt engineer"; they become the analyst, accountant, or tax associate who finishes in 40 minutes what a peer takes a day to do, and who can defend every number.

Concretely, AI shows up in finance work in four places:

Layer	Tool examples	Finance task it touches
Assistant / chat	ChatGPT, Claude, Copilot, Gemini	Draft variance commentary, explain a formula, summarise a 200-page annual report, write SQL/DAX for you
Embedded copilots	Excel Copilot, Power BI Copilot, Tally add-ons, Zoho	In-app formula generation, "explain this pivot", auto-categorise ledgers
Document AI / OCR	Nanonets, Docsumo, GST-portal auto-populate (GSTR-2B), bank-statement parsers	Invoice/PO/bank-statement extraction into structured data
Custom automation	Python + LLM APIs, RPA (UiPath), macros	Batch reconciliation, exception flagging, three-way match, board-pack generation

Roles that now expect this: FP&A analyst, financial analyst, controller/accounts manager, tax associate (Direct + GST), internal audit, equity research, and treasury. In India specifically, mid-size firms and Big-4 + next-tier (BDO, Grant Thornton, Nexdigm) are hiring associates who can "do more with less" — the AI-fluent CA-Inter/MBA is exactly that profile.

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

Your MBA taught you *what* a DCF is and *why* WACC matters. It did not teach you that a controller now expects the month-end commentary drafted by an LLM and then **fact-checked and corrected by you** in 20 minutes. CA coursework drills the Companies Act and Ind AS — it does not drill feeding a trial balance into a model, catching the three hallucinated numbers, and shipping a clean schedule.

The gap is specific and it is about **judgement over output**:

- College rewards you for producing an answer. Industry now assumes the machine produces a first draft; you are paid to **verify, correct, and take ownership**.
- College treats tools as separate subjects. Industry needs them stitched: OCR pulls invoices → Python reconciles → LLM drafts the note → you sign off.
- College never taught **where AI is dangerous**: it invents citations, mis-reads a bracketed negative as positive, confidently averages the wrong column. Firms have been burned by juniors who pasted ChatGPT output into a filing.

So the thing companies actually pay a premium for is not "can you use ChatGPT" — everyone can. It is: **can you use it fast AND catch its mistakes AND explain your control over it to an auditor**.

What "proficient" looks like

The employer's bar — what a job-ready person does unaided:

1. **Reframes a finance task into a good prompt** with role, context, data, format, and constraints — not "write me a variance analysis".
2. **Never trusts a number blindly.** Ties every AI-produced figure back to the source (trial balance, GSTR-2B, bank statement) before it leaves their desk.
3. **Uses AI to write tools, not just prose** — generates a working SQL query, an Excel formula, a Python reconciliation script, then reviews it line by line.
4. **Knows the data-security line:** never pastes client PII, unmasked PAN/GSTIN, salary data, or unpublished financials into a public chatbot. Uses enterprise/redacted versions.
5. **Automates one repetitive close/tax task** end-to-end and can show the before/after time saving.
6. **Explains the audit trail:** "AI drafted, I verified against X, here's my working."

Hands-on: how to actually do it

1. A reusable finance prompt skeleton

```
Role: You are a senior FP&A analyst.  
Context: Indian manufacturing SME, FY25-26, INR, figures in lakhs.  
Data: [paste trial balance / table]  
Task: Draft budget-vs-actual variance commentary for opex.  
Rules: Only use numbers I gave you. Flag any figure you had to  
       assume. Show % variance = (Actual-Budget)/Budget. No advice  
       beyond the data. Output: 5 bullets, then a 3-column table.
```

The three rules — *only my numbers, flag assumptions, show the formula* — are what stop hallucination.

2. Let AI write the Excel, then you own it

Ask: "XLOOKUP to pull GST rate from a rate master, return 0 if not found." You should be able to read and correct what it returns:

```
=XLOOKUP(B2, RateMaster!A:A, RateMaster!B:B, 0, 0)  
  
=LET(sales, SUMIFS(Data[Amt], Data[Region], A2),  
     tax,    sales*0.18,  
     sales + tax)
```

If the model gives you `VLOOKUP` with a hardcoded column index, you *fix it* to `XLOOKUP` — that judgement is the skill.

3. Generate SQL for a reconciliation, review before running

Prompt: "SQL: find invoices in our books not in GSTR-2B, MySQL." Expected output you must be able to vet:

```

SELECT b.invoice_no, b.gstin, b.taxable_val, b.igst
FROM   books_purchase b
LEFT   JOIN gstr2b g
      ON b.invoice_no = g.invoice_no
      AND b.gstin      = g.gstin
WHERE  g.invoice_no IS NULL      -- in books, missing in 2B
ORDER BY b.taxable_val DESC;

```

Red flag to catch: if the AI joins on `invoice_no` alone, duplicate invoice numbers across vendors give false matches. You add `AND b.gstin = g.gstin`. That correction is why they hired you, not the bot.

4. Python: batch-parse bank statements the AI helped you write

```

import pandas as pd

# read all monthly statements, tag credits/debits, flag round-number txns
df = pd.read_excel("bank_stmt.xlsx")
df["type"] = df["amount"].apply(lambda x: "credit" if x > 0 else "debit")
df["round_flag"] = (df["amount"].abs() % 10000 == 0) # audit red flag
suspense = df[df["narration"].str.contains("SUSPENSE|UNKNOWN",
                                             case=False, na=False)]
print(suspense[["date", "amount", "narration"]])

```

Always print a control total and tie it to the closing balance before trusting the output.

5. Power BI DAX the copilot drafts, you validate

```

Actual vs Budget % =
DIVIDE(
    SUM(Fact[Actual]) - SUM(Fact[Budget]),
    SUM(Fact[Budget])
)

```

Check the copilot didn't use `/` (which errors on zero budget) instead of `DIVIDE`.

6. GST-portal + AI reconciliation flow (India)

1. `services.gst.gov.in` → Returns Dashboard → download **GSTR-2B** (JSON/Excel).
2. Export purchase register from TallyPrime: **Gateway** → **Display** → **Account Books** → **Purchase Register** → **Alt+E (Export)** → **Excel**.
3. Feed both into the SQL/Python match above, or paste summarised columns into an LLM to draft the mismatch email to vendors.
4. **You** decide ITC eligibility — never the bot (Rule 37, Sec 16(2)(c) are judgement calls).

Worked example / mini-project

Goal: AI-assisted GST ITC reconciliation for a Bengaluru trading firm, Jun 2026.

Data (books purchase register, ₹ in full):

Invoice	Vendor GSTIN	Taxable	IGST
INV-101	29ABCDE1234F1Z5	2,00,000	36,000
INV-102	29PQRST5678K1Z2	1,50,000	27,000
INV-103	27LMNOP9012J1Z8	3,00,000	54,000

GSTR-2B (as downloaded): contains INV-101 and INV-103 only. INV-102 is missing (vendor hasn't filed).

Step 1 — AI drafts the reco logic, you run the SQL from section 3. Output: INV-102 flagged.

Step 2 — Journal impact. ITC on INV-102 (₹27,000) cannot be claimed this month. Provisional entry to hold it:

Particulars	Dr (₹)	Cr (₹)
Purchases A/c	1,50,000	
ITC Ineligible/Blocked (2B mismatch) A/c	27,000	
To Vendor (Sundry Creditor) A/c		1,77,000

When the vendor files and INV-102 appears in a later 2B, reverse the block and claim:

Particulars	Dr (₹)	Cr (₹)
Input IGST A/c	27,000	
To ITC Ineligible/Blocked A/c		27,000

Step 3 — AI drafts the vendor email, you edit: "INV-102 (₹1,77,000) not reflecting in our June GSTR-2B; ITC of ₹27,000 withheld until your GSTR-1 is filed."

Result: eligible ITC this month = 36,000 + 54,000 = **₹90,000**, ₹27,000 correctly deferred. A task that is 2 hours by hand is ~25 minutes — and you can defend every rupee. That defensibility is the deliverable.

How it's tested

Interviews and practical screens for AI-era finance roles:

Conceptual / judgement questions - "You asked ChatGPT for a variance analysis and it gave a number that doesn't tie to the TB. What do you do?" (Answer: trace to source, never ship unverified.) - "What would you *never* paste into a public LLM?" (Client PII, PAN/GSTIN, salaries, unpublished results, MNPI.) - "Where does AI fail in a GST reco?" (ITC eligibility, Rule 37 reversal, blocked credits u/s 17(5) — human calls.)

Practical assessments companies actually give - **A timed case:** "Here's a trial balance and a messy AI-drafted commentary — find and fix the 3 errors in 20 minutes." - **A live tool test:** "Write a prompt to reconcile these two files, then show me the Excel/SQL you'd use." They watch whether you verify. - **A "close these books" case** where using AI is *allowed* and they judge your control, audit trail, and speed — not

whether you memorised formulas. - Excel + Power BI hands-on where Copilot is enabled and they see if you catch its **DIVIDE** /join mistakes.

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

Mistake	How pros avoid it
Pasting client PII/GSTIN/salary into a public chatbot	Redact first, or use enterprise/on-prem tools; know the firm's AI policy
Trusting AI numbers without trying to source	Always reconcile to TB / 2B / bank balance before shipping
Accepting hallucinated citations (a fake ICAI para, a wrong section)	Verify every legal/standard reference against the bare act/standard
Vague prompts → vague junk	Use the role-context-data-format-rules skeleton
Letting AI do the <i>judgement</i> (ITC eligibility, provisioning, going concern)	AI drafts, human decides; keep the call yours
No audit trail — "the AI said so"	Document: prompt used, source verified, your correction
Using AI to <i>replace</i> learning fundamentals	Learn the concept first so you can catch the bot's errors

The one-line rule: **AI is a fast intern, not a partner. You review its work; you sign the file.**

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Realistic time-to-proficiency: **4–6 weeks** part-time to be interview-ready, assuming you already know Excel and basic accounting.

Week	Focus	Deliverable
1	Prompting for finance; the RCDFR skeleton; data-security rules	10 saved prompts for your real tasks
2	AI-assisted Excel/DAX; catch its mistakes	Rebuild a report with Copilot, log every error you caught
3	SQL + Python for reconciliation (AI writes, you review)	The GST/bank reco mini-project above
4	Document AI / OCR + end-to-end automation	One repetitive close task automated, timed before/after
5–6	Audit trail, governance, mock timed case	A 1-page "how I use AI safely" you can talk through

Resources - Free: OpenAI/Anthropic prompting guides; Microsoft *Copilot in Excel/Power BI* Learn modules; freeCodeCamp Python; Mode SQL tutorial; the GST portal's own advisories. - Paid: Coursera *Generative AI for Business/Finance*; Wall Street Prep / CFI AI-for-finance modules; DataCamp Python-for-finance track. - India-specific: ICAI's Digital Accounting & Assurance Board material; TallyPrime + GST reco practice. - Certifications

worth listing on a CV: Microsoft **PL-300** (Power BI), any recognised Generative-AI-for-Finance course. No single "AI finance" cert is a must-have yet — the **portfolio of an automated task** beats a certificate.

Quick-reference

Need	Copy-usable
Prompt skeleton	Role → Context → Data → Task → Rules (only my numbers / flag assumptions / show formula)
Lookup	=XLOOKUP(key, lookup_col, return_col, 0, 0)
Safe division (DAX)	DIVIDE(num, den) — never /
Variance %	(Actual - Budget) / Budget
SQL: in books, not in 2B	LEFT JOIN ... ON invoice_no AND gstin WHERE g.invoice_no IS NULL
Python control check	Print df["amount"].sum() , tie to closing balance
GST reco path	GST portal → GSTR-2B ↓ · Tally → Purchase Register → Alt+E ↓ · match
Never paste	PII, PAN/GSTIN, salaries, unpublished results, MNPI
Golden rule	AI drafts → you verify to source → you sign
ITC block entry	Dr Purchases, Dr ITC-Ineligible, Cr Creditor; reverse when 2B updates

Master Resource List & 12-Month Plan

What it is & where it's used

This is the capstone chapter: a single, curated list of every course, book, channel, and dataset worth your time — mapped onto a **12-month calendar** that turns the whole Playbook into a schedule you can actually follow. No new tool here; the "skill" is **learning-project management**: sequencing skills so each one compounds into the next (Excel → SQL → Python → BI → domain), and producing *proof-of-work* (a GitHub repo, a dashboard, a reconciled book) that a hiring manager can click.

It's used by every early-career finance candidate — MBA + CA-Inter, B.Com + interviewing, or a working analyst trying to move from "MIS person" to "FP&A / data / tax specialist." Recruiters don't hire syllabi; they hire someone who can show a completed thing. This chapter is how you build a stack of completed things in a year while still clearing CA papers.

The gap: why companies want this (and college didn't teach it)

College hands you 40 subjects and zero prioritisation. You graduate "knowing" accounting, stats, finance, and IT — none of it to a *job-ready depth*, and nothing integrated. Employers, by contrast, want a **T-shaped** person: broad awareness, one or two spikes deep enough to be trusted unaided on day one.

What college optimises for	What employers pay for
Coverage (pass 40 subjects)	Depth (own 2 skills end-to-end)
Individual exams	A portfolio of shipped deliverables
Theory you can recite	A model/query/return you can <i>produce</i>
Fixed 3-year timeline	Self-directed 90-day skill sprints

The missing meta-skill is **deliberate sequencing under a deadline** — exactly what a 12-month plan enforces. Do it and you arrive at interviews with a link, not a promise.

What "proficient" looks like

A job-ready person, unaided, can:

- **Excel/FP&A**: build a 3-statement model with a working circular-reference switch; use `XLOOKUP` , `SUMIFS` , `INDEX/MATCH` , dynamic arrays; write a variance commentary.
- **Accounting/Tax**: pass any routine journal, close a trial balance, file GSTR-1 / GSTR-3B, reconcile GSTR-2B to books, compute TDS and advance tax.
- **SQL**: join 3+ tables, window functions, CTEs — pull a P&L from raw ledgers.
- **Python**: clean a messy CSV with `pandas` , automate a monthly report.
- **BI**: a Power BI dashboard with DAX measures (`Total Sales` , `YoY%` , running totals).
- **Meta**: a public GitHub with 3–4 mini-projects and a one-line README each.

The bar is "**can you do it live, on a timer, without Google for the basics.**"

Hands-on: how to actually do it

The engine of the year is a repeating **90-day skill sprint**. Each sprint: *Learn* (weeks 1–4) → *Build* (5–10) → *Ship + document* (11–12). Track it in one Excel sheet so the plan is itself a proof of your Excel.

Build a self-updating tracker. Columns: Skill | Sprint | StartDate | TargetDate | Status | ProofURL .

```
# % of the year elapsed, live:
=TEXT((TODAY()-DATE(2026,7,1))/365,"0.0%")

# Days left in the current sprint:
=[@TargetDate]-TODAY()

# RAG status flag:
=IF([@Status]="Done", "🟢", IF([@TargetDate]-TODAY()<0, "🔴", "🟡"))

# Count of shipped proofs:
=COUNTIF(Tracker[Status], "Done")

# Pull the next unfinished skill (dynamic array):
=FILTER(Tracker[Skill], Tracker[Status] <> "Done")
```

SQL to log study hours in a tiny SQLite/Postgres table and see weekly pace:

```
SELECT strftime('%Y-%W', log_date) AS week,
       skill,
       SUM(hours) AS hrs
FROM   study_log
GROUP BY week, skill
HAVING SUM(hours) > 0
ORDER BY week DESC;
```

Python to nag yourself — pulls the tracker and prints red items:

```
import pandas as pd, datetime as dt
df = pd.read_excel("tracker.xlsx", sheet_name="Tracker")
today = pd.Timestamp(dt.date.today())
overdue = df[(df.Status != "Done") & (df.TargetDate < today)]
print(f"{len(overdue)} skill(s) slipping:")
print(overdue[["Skill", "TargetDate"]].to_string(index=False))
```

DAX measure for a "career progress" card in Power BI:

```
Skills Shipped % =
DIVIDE(
    CALCULATE(COUNTROWS(Tracker), Tracker[Status] = "Done"),
    COUNTROWS(Tracker)
)
```

Worked example / mini-project

Project: "One-Year Finance Skills Dashboard." Realistic India-context plan for a CA-Inter candidate starting July 2026.

The 12-month map (study alongside CA, ~10 hrs/week on skills):

Month	Sprint focus	Ship (proof-of-work)	Primary resource
Jul–Aug	Advanced Excel + FP&A	3-statement model of a listed Indian FMCG (from annual report)	Wall Street Prep / CFI Excel
Sep	Accounting close + Tally	Closed a set of books; trial balance → P&L	TallyPrime + ICAI notes
Oct–Nov	GST + TDS practical	Filed a dummy GSTR-1/3B; GSTR-2B reco sheet	GST portal + ClearTax blog
Dec	SQL for finance	Query pack pulling P&L from raw sales table	Mode SQL Tutorial (free)
Jan–Feb	Python + pandas	Auto monthly MIS from 3 CSVs	Kaggle "Pandas" micro-course
Mar	Power BI + DAX	Sales & AR dashboard, 8 measures	Microsoft Learn (free)
Apr	Financial modelling / valuation	DCF + comps of the same FMCG	Aswath Damodaran (free)
May	Capstone + portfolio	GitHub README linking all six	—
Jun	Interview prep + polish	Mock tests, resume rewrite	This Playbook

Concrete numbers to reproduce the Excel piece: take Hindustan Unilever-style figures — Revenue ₹62,000 cr, EBITDA margin 24%, tax rate 25.17%, capex ₹1,200 cr, WC days 15. Build the model, then flex revenue growth 6%/8%/10% and watch FCF. The *deliverable* is one `.xlsx` with a scenario dropdown, pushed to GitHub — that single file beats "MBA Finance" on a resume.

A sample journal from the Sept close sprint, to prove the accounting spike:

Date	Particulars	Dr (₹)	Cr (₹)
30-Sep	Depreciation A/c Dr	50,000	
	To Accumulated Depreciation A/c		50,000
30-Sep	Salaries A/c Dr	2,00,000	
	To Salaries Payable A/c		2,00,000
30-Sep	Profit & Loss A/c Dr	2,50,000	
	To Depreciation A/c		50,000
	To Salaries A/c		2,00,000

How it's tested

Hiring for these roles almost always includes a **practical**, not just a chat:

- **FP&A / analyst:** a *timed 45-min Excel case* — "here's a raw sales dump, build a summary P&L with SUMIFS and a pivot, comment on the biggest variance." No formulas from memory = fail.
- **Data-leaning finance:** a *SQL screen* on HackerRank / DataLemur — 2–3 questions, usually a window function and a self-join.
- **Accounts / audit:** a *"close these books"* case — you're handed a trial balance with errors to find, or asked to pass adjusting entries live.
- **Tax:** compute TDS on a set of invoices, or reconcile GSTR-2B mismatches and state the ITC allowed.
- **Interview questions:** "Walk me through your 3-statement model." / "How did you build that dashboard — what's the DAX?" / "Show me your GitHub." The follow-ups probe whether *you* did it.

The tell that separates you: you can screen-share and *do the thing*, because you shipped six of them this year.

Common mistakes & how pros avoid them

- **Tutorial hell.** Watching 40 hours, building nothing. Pros cap learning at ~30% of sprint time; the rest is building.
- **Breadth with no spike.** "A little Python, a little BI, a little SQL" impresses no one. Go deep on one per sprint.
- **No proof.** If it's not on GitHub or a shareable file, it didn't happen to a recruiter.
- **Buying every course.** 90% of what you need is free (below). Pros pay only for structured modelling (WSP/CFI) or a domain cert.
- **Ignoring the CA overlap.** Your CA tax/audit/costing papers *are* domain depth — reuse them as portfolio topics, don't treat them as separate.
- **Perfectionism.** A shipped B-grade dashboard beats an unfinished A-grade one. Timebox, then ship.

Learn-it roadmap & resources

Time-to-proficiency: ~10 hrs/week for 12 months gets you interview-ready in 2–3 skills. Each 90-day sprint = one credible spike.

The master list (free unless noted):

Skill	Best resource	Cost
Excel/FP&A	CFI FMVA (paid), Wall Street Prep, ExcellsFun (YouTube)	Free– ₹30k
Modelling/Valuation	Aswath Damodaran (NYU, free lectures + spreadsheets)	Free
Accounting/Tax	ICAI study material, ClearTax & TaxGuru blogs, CA Rachana Ranade (YT)	Free
Tally/GST	TallyPrime learning portal, GST portal (practice with dummy GSTIN)	Free
SQL	Mode SQL Tutorial, DataLemur, SQLBolt	Free
Python	Kaggle micro-courses, "Automate the Boring Stuff" (free book)	Free
Power BI/DAX	Microsoft Learn, SQLBI (Marco Russo), Guy in a Cube (YT)	Free
Books	<i>Financial Modeling</i> (Benninga), <i>Storytelling with Data</i> (Knaflic), <i>Naked Statistics</i> (Wheelan)	Paid
Portfolio	GitHub + a one-page Notion/PDF case study each	Free

Certifications worth it (India-relevant): CFA/FRM if going capital-markets/risk; NISM for securities roles; Microsoft PL-300 for Power BI; your CA itself is the strongest single credential — finish it. Skip generic "Udemy certificates" — they signal nothing.

Quick-reference

Item	Value
Sprint length	90 days: Learn (4w) → Build (6w) → Ship (2w)
Weekly commitment	~10 hrs skills, on top of CA study
Learn:Build ratio	30 : 70
Sprints in the year	4 major + 2 short = 6 shipped proofs
Progress formula	<code>= (TODAY() - DATE(2026, 7, 1)) / 365</code>
Overdue flag	<code>= IF([@TargetDate] - TODAY() < 0, "🔴", "🟢")</code>
Shipped count	<code>= COUNTIF(Tracker[Status], "Done")</code>
SQL pace check	<code>GROUP BY strftime('%Y-%W', log_date)</code>
DAX progress	<code>DIVIDE(done_rows, total_rows)</code>
Non-negotiable	Every sprint ends with a public, clickable deliverable
Free stack	Mode (SQL) · Kaggle (Python) · MS Learn (BI) · Damodaran (valuation)
Paid, if any	CFI/WSP (Excel modelling); PL-300 (BI); finish CA

The one rule that makes the year work: never finish a sprint without a link you can paste into a resume. Six links in twelve months closes the MBA-to-employer gap for good.